AYUMU ROUTE

Chapter 1: Morning duty

Student
"Good morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Student
"Good morning, President Hoshina. Vice President Anesaki."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."

…Ah.
Suddenly, my attention was drawn to a figure approaching from ahead.
There was nothing particularly flashy about him, yet somehow, he seemed out of place among the people around him.
Perhaps "somber" was the best way to describe his presence. The way his long hair obscured his face while he read was a little eerie, too.
Either way, he stood out, though not for any particularly good reasons.
...And then Kuraguchi-kun looked up, and our eyes met.
I quickly averted my gaze and mechanically gave my greeting, pretending as though nothing had happened.

Another

Nozomi Anesaki
"G-good morning."

I'll just do my duty and give him the greeting required of me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good morning."

Kuraguchi-kun casually returned the greeting and passed through the gate without stopping.
Ah... thank goodness. Everything is fine.
Just as relief washed over me, I also found myself feeling strangely disappointed.
I kept telling myself to move on from the past, but those memories of the fun times we shared still lingered, refusing to disappear.
(Go to "Conclusion".)

Happy

Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Good morning..."

Kuraguchi-kun returned a quiet, merely formal greeting before walking through the gate.
...Ah... this felt kind of bad…
(Go to "Conclusion".)

Conclusion

Mizuho Hoshina
"That person just now... could he be the transfer student?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Y-yes... that's right."
Mizuho Hoshina
"I hope he'll like our school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah, haha... Y-yeah… Me too..."

Ugh... Senpai's radiant beauty served as a cruel reminder.
Once again, I was forced to confront my ugly nature, and an overwhelming sense of self-loathing washed over me.

Chapter 2: Acting like strangers

After finishing my morning duty, I made my way back to the classroom, only to stop at the door.
For some reason, I suddenly felt reluctant to go inside... perhaps because Kuraguchi-kun's face had flashed through my mind.
...No, that's bad. I shouldn't let it bother me.
I straightened my back and confidently walked in.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning."
Male student
"Ah, Anesaki-san!"
Female student
"Morning, Nozomi!"
Female student
"Mooorning."

Perfect. Still getting the right reactions today. This is exactly how "Nozomi Anesaki's" life is supposed to be.

I exchanged greetings with everyone as usual and quietly took my seat, pretending nothing was amiss.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Another

Kuraguchi-kun was reading his book.
I mean... we're still classmates, so I guess I should at least say hi.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...M-morning..."

When I spoke to him, Kuraguchi-kun turned toward me, looking slightly surprised.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Good morning, Anesaki-san."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

...The conversation didn't really go anywhere.
I finally looked away from Kuraguchi-kun and busied myself with organising my things. He silently resumed reading as well.
And that was it. We didn't say another word to each other.
Well... for "ordinary classmates," I suppose this is pretty normal...

Female student
"...And that's what happened. Isn't it just aaawful?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's pretty terrible…"
Male student
"Anesaki-san, how do you solve this one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's see... you substitute the value obtained from the previous problem into x, and then…"

The break had just started, and students immediately came over and crowded around my desk.
They probably felt more comfortable gathering around since Miho was absent today with a cold.
I glanced sideways at the seat next to me.
As always, Kuraguchi-kun was sitting by himself, quietly reading his book.
Come to think of it, I haven't seen him talk to anyone except me since yesterday.
I'd vaguely suspected as much, but it seems he really hasn't been able to find his place in this class.

Miho Orikasa
"Try to get along with him, Miss Class Rep."

"Get along with him," you say...
I can't figure out how I'm supposed to interact with Kuraguchi-kun as the "Nozomi Anesaki" I am now without telling him about the past.
At this point, all I can manage is the occasional harmless greeting.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

All of a sudden, Kuraguchi-kun quietly stood up.
He left the classroom without saying a word.
We all just watched him as he did.

Female student
"What was that...? He's kinda rude..."

One of the girls murmured under her breath.
...Well, I suppose we were being quite a nuisance. You were putting far too much of your weight on Kuraguchi-kun's desk, for one thing.

Male student
"I can't stand that guy. He glared at me for some reason this morning."
Male student
"Really? That gloomy loner?"
Male student
"Yeah. All he ever does is sit there reading novels."

Quiet giggles followed.
I kept smiling, though my expression was starting to stiffen.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Excuse me, I'm going to the bathroom for a moment."
Female student
"Oh, okay. Go ahead."
Male student
"Can I come along?"
Female student
"You can't do that, you know. That's sexual harassment."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha… I'll be right back."

I left the classroom and hurried after Kuraguchi-kun.
I found him just around the corner and cautiously called out to him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um, Kuraguchi-kun..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"

Kuraguchi-kun turned around and stopped, seemingly startled.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Anesaki-san...? Did you need something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... well... I'm sorry about earlier."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We were getting in your way, weren't we?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"

Kuraguchi-kun tilted his head, looking like he had no idea what I was talking about.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You know... we were pushing your desk in pretty far..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ah, ohh... that's what you were talking about."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sorry... We disturbed your reading..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh? You thought that was why I left my seat...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It wasn't?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"S-sorry... I didn't think you would take it that way. I just needed to use the bathroom..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... Oh, I see..."

Oh, so I'd just jumped to conclusions.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But... we were still getting in your way. I'm sorry... I'll be more careful from now on."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... no, it's okay. It honestly doesn't bother me."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Besides, I usually spend break time in the library anyway, so it really isn't something you need to concern yourself with."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... Is that so?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. ...Sorry for making you worry."

...I think he's the one worrying about my feelings here...

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Well then, I'll get going."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... yeah. Sorry for keeping you..."

I watched his back as he walked away.
I guess this kind of distance between us is probably for the best, but somehow, I couldn't quite feel at ease.
(Go to the next chapter.)

Happy

Kuraguchi-kun was reading his book in silence.
Well... That makes sense. No one would calmly greet a person who'd gone as far as to bluntly say "Stay away from me."
Naturally, I didn't greet him either. I deliberately shut him out of my line of sight completely and put my things away in my desk.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

I suddenly realized Miho wasn't here yet. She'd usually have been at school for a while by now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, Miho hasn't shown up yet?"

I asked the girl sitting in front of me.

Female student
"Yeah, apparently she's out sick today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Female student
"Lucky her. We have P.E. today. I wanna skip it too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha."

Miho's absent today, huh... ...Hmm...
For the most part, the students in our class tend to stick together in small groups of two or three.
Sometimes we hang out in bigger groups during break, but usually, it's just me and Miho.
So if Miho isn't here, that means I'll be on my own—

Female student
"Nozomi-chaan! What's the answer to this one?"
Male student
"Can you help me with this one, too?"

I found myself surrounded by cheerful faces again today. I didn't end up alone.
I suppose this is what my position in the school social hierarchy affords me.
I glanced sideways at the seat next to me.
As always, Kuraguchi-kun was sitting by himself, quietly reading his book.
Come to think of it, I haven't seen him talk to anyone except me since yesterday.
I'd vaguely suspected as much, but it seems he really hasn't been able to find his place in this class.

Miho Orikasa
"Try to get along with him, Miss Class Rep."

No... absolutely not, no way, no way...
I'm the class representative, not his personal caretaker.
And besides, I already told him to stay away from me. ...And I don't want to get involved with him, either.

Female student
"Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, sorry. Um, so, for this problem..."

Just ignore him. Ignore him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

All of a sudden, Kuraguchi-kun quietly stood up.
He left the classroom without saying a word.
We all just watched him as he did.

Female student
"What was that...? He's kinda rude..."

One of the girls murmured under her breath.
...Well, I suppose we were being quite a nuisance. You were putting far too much of your weight on Kuraguchi-kun's desk, for one thing.

Male student
"I can't stand that guy. He glared at me for some reason this morning."
Male student
"Really? That gloomy loner?"
Male student
"Yeah. All he ever does is sit there reading novels."

Quiet giggles followed.
I kept smiling, though my expression was starting to stiffen.
None of what they were saying was directed at me, but I felt like I'd been getting stabbed through the chest this whole time.

Female student
"Poor Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Male student
"Yeah, they stuck him next to you just because you're the class rep."
Female student
"Hopefully we'll change seats soon."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... haha..."

I'd rather change classmates.
I wonder if Kuraguchi-kun can really make it through the next six months in a class like this.
...No, no. It'll be fine. It's fine.
The only problem is break time.
Everyone's by themselves during lessons, after all. In that sense, most of school life is lonely.
I tried to convince myself of that for some reason.
And yet…

Teacher
"Let's begin our English conversation practice. Please form groups of two or three."

.....
I felt like burying my head in my hands.
Why now, of all times, did he have to come up with such a cruel idea?

Male student
"Let's team up."
Male student
"Yeah."

Everyone left their seats and started forming their groups.
Before long, the scene I'd seen during break was playing out in the classroom again.
Naturally, I...

Female student
"Nozomi! Come join us!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, sure!"

...had no problem finding a group. Miho wasn't here, but two girls sitting nearby invited me to join them.
And, of course, Kuraguchi-kun...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

...was all alone.
Everyone else was on their feet, but he remained seated, his gaze fixed intently on the surface of his desk.

Teacher
"Oh?"

The teacher surveyed the classroom before his eyes settled on Kuraguchi-kun, prompting him to tilt his head.

Teacher
"You're... um... oh, right. You're the transfer student."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... yes."
Teacher
"Okay, those of you working in pairs, please let Kuraguchi-kun join you."

The chatter in the classroom died down.
...Heh.
I realized that someone laughed. Perhaps people were encouraged by that, because a few more snickers started spreading around the room.
Ughhhhh... What is this? What is with this horribly uncomfortable atmosphere...?
Unable to bear it any longer, I instinctively covered my face with both hands.

Teacher
"Ah... Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes?!"
Teacher
"Pair up with Kuraguchi-kun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

The classroom stirred with a faint murmur.

Female students
"Nozomi..."

The two girls I was supposed to pair up with gave me sympathetic looks.
This can't be happening... No way, no way, no way...
Right?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."

With all kinds of complicated emotions swirling inside me, I could only nod solemnly and play the part of the responsible class representative.

Teacher
"All right. Three minutes of free talk. Start!"

When the teacher clapped his hands, the classroom immediately erupted into chatter.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

Meanwhile, silence hung between Kuraguchi-kun and me.
In fact, we both kept our eyes lowered, avoiding eye contact with each other.

Teacher
"Anesaki-san, Kuraguchi-kun, get to work."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

I'd always made a point of maintaining my good-student persona, so being scolded over something like this was embarrassing.
Reluctantly, I raised my head and put on my usual polite smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hello..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hello."

Whoa... Kuraguchi-kun's pronunciation is actually really good.
...No, that's beside the point.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

The conversation just isn't going anywhere... What should I do? What am I even supposed to talk about...?
After "Hello," I guess the usual thing would be to ask, "How are you?"
But seriously, asking that when he looks anything but fine would be pretty stupid.
Still, I couldn't come up with another topic. Even if we weren't speaking English, I still wouldn't have known what to say to Kuraguchi-kun.
...It's strange. We weren't like this before.
Back then, no matter how much we talked, new topics just kept popping up. Ten minutes of break time was hardly enough for us.
I never once had trouble finding something to talk about with Kuraguchi-kun.

Teacher
"All right, time's up."

The teacher clapped his hands once more.

And so, after three whole minutes, the only word Kuraguchi-kun and I had exchanged was "Hello."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

I'm exhausted... Why am I this worn out after an English class...?
It's not like I was doing anything strenuous like in P.E....
.....
Oh, right. We have P.E. today, don't we?
Something tells me this isn't going to end well... I hope I'm wrong…

I guess there's some truth to the saying that your worst premonitions tend to come true.

Teacher
"Okay, let's do a warm-up. Pair up, everyone."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Once again, I felt like burying my face in my hands.
I'd completely forgotten about it since starting high school, but apparently, there are more obstacles to getting through school life than I'd previously thought.

Female student
"Nozomi! Wanna do it together?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... yeah, sure."

Most people would likely never become aware of just how unforgiving it could be.
But for a select few...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Ah... just as I thought.
Kuraguchi-kun was standing all by himself, completely left out of the circle.
But I couldn't do anything about it. All I could do was pretend not to notice.

Teacher
"Ooh? Looks like we've got one person left over!"

The teacher let out a hearty laugh.
I knew he didn't mean any harm, but he was only encouraging the students to snicker, so I really wished he'd stop.

Teacher
"What should we do, I wonder? Hmm?"

The teacher glanced briefly in my direction.
Gulp.
...For the record, I'm currently in a group of three. With Miho absent, there are an odd number of girls, leaving one girl without a partner.
Don't tell me I'm going to be paired up with Kuraguchi-kun again...
...That thought crossed my mind for only a second. The teacher didn't say a word and simply looked away.

Teacher
"All right, Kuraguchi! You're partnering with me!!!"

"Gahahaha!" The teacher laughed as he gave Kuraguchi-kun a firm pat on the back.
Kuraguchi-kun stumbled from the impact.
And then the boys around him burst into laughter.

Female student
"Lucky you, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hahaha..."

This was also incredibly uncomfortable in its own way…
(Go to the next chapter.)

Chapter 3: Those familiar eyes

Another

The bell for the start of sixth period finally rang.
Perhaps today felt so long because I couldn't stop thinking about Kuraguchi-kun.
We hadn't really talked since then.
Whenever break time started, Kuraguchi-kun would disappear from the classroom. The other students didn't seem to pay much attention to him either.
From the looks of things, I don't have to worry about my position being threatened, and I should be able to continue living the same peaceful school life I've always had.
...But still...
I glanced sideways to check on Kuraguchi-kun.
He appeared to be searching through his desk for something. I wonder what's wrong...
(Go to "Common.")

Happy

The bell for the start of sixth period finally rang.
By then, I was utterly drained.
Today felt like it had been ridiculously long. Probably because I'd been kept on edge twice during classes.

Teacher
"All right, let's get started with modern Japanese."

The teacher stood at the front of the classroom.
Modern Japanese, huh... Surely we won't be told to "form groups" in this class too...
I felt a little relieved as I took out my textbook, when I sensed some movement coming from Kuraguchi-kun beside me.
What could he be doing...?
I quietly peeked over.
After digging through his desk for a while, Kuraguchi-kun's shoulders sank in disappointment.
Don't tell me…
(Go to "Common.")

Common

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Um..."

Kuraguchi-kun hesitantly raised his hand. The entire class turned their attention to him.

Teacher
"Yes? Um... you're Ayumu Kuraguchi-kun, right? What is it?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Sorry, I forgot my textbook."

A few students snickered.
The moment anything happens, they jump at the chance to pick on him. It really gets on my nerves.

Teacher
"I see, I see. In that case... Anesaki-san, please share your textbook with him."

...Yeah, I guess that figures.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course..."

I moved my desk next to Kuraguchi-kun's.
He looked so incredibly apologetic that I suddenly felt awful.
I didn't like seeing him act so distant with me.
...Huh. What am I even thinking? I'm the one who's been acting that way toward him.

Teacher
"...And this is where the paragraph ends..."

After that little mishap at the start, the lesson continued without incident.

Still, I couldn't quite focus on the class, and I found myself staring blankly at the writing on the blackboard.
…Then I heard the continuous scratching of a pen from right beside me.
I instinctively glanced over and saw Kuraguchi-kun diligently writing away in his notebook.
...What could he possibly have so much to write about? It's not as though we have that much to copy from the board right now.
As I wondered about it, my eyes naturally drifted toward his profile...
And my heart skipped a beat at the sight.
His eyes were mostly obscured by his long bangs.
I could only see the tiniest sliver of them through the gap, but there was something beautiful about the way he gazed so intently at his notebook.
Ah... I had the same thought yesterday. Those were Ayumu-kun's eyes. The eyes that were so familiar.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Suddenly, Kuraguchi-kun turned to look at me. He had a somewhat strange expression on his face.
I hurriedly faced forward again. My heart jumped for a moment. The entire class was staring at me.

Teacher
"Um... Anesaki-san? Could you read the next part for us?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes!"

Aaaahhh! What am I doing?!
I was so distracted by Kuraguchi-kun that I completely missed the teacher calling on me.
This is utterly unbecoming of a model student.
I hurriedly took my textbook and rose to my feet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Waaaahhhh! Where are we nowww...?
I hadn't been following along at all. I glanced at the blackboard, but there was nothing particularly helpful written there.

Teacher
"Anesaki-san? Is everything all right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yes... Um..."

Ughhh... I really don't want to ask, "Where are we now?"... It'd be painfully obvious that I wasn't paying attention.
I don't want to make a fool of myself twice in one class… but... I don't know what else to do...

Students
"..."

Looks like I'm on my own.
Well, naturally... Who would ever suspect that I wasn't listening to the lesson...
Sigh... I suppose I'll just have to be honest...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Um..."

Just as I steeled myself and opened my mouth...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"By then, I was..."

Kuraguchi-kun suddenly murmured. His voice was so quiet that I was probably the only one who could hear him.
I turned toward him in surprise. But Kuraguchi-kun simply kept his eyes on his notebook, as if nothing had happened.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...'By then, I was already a university student. For the first time, my teacher's—' "
Teacher
"All right, thank you, Anesaki-san. Please take your seat. The next sentence..."

I finished reading and quietly returned to my seat, still dazed.
Kuraguchi-kun continued writing intently in his notebook.

Another conclusion

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um..."

When I timidly spoke to him, Kuraguchi-kun looked up with a startled expression, covering his notebook with both hands.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?! Wh-what...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... um, thank you. For telling me where to read..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, ohh... No... I'm the one who should be thanking you for sharing your textbook with me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you see it properly?"

I slid the textbook a little closer to Kuraguchi-kun's side of the desk, but he hurriedly pushed it back.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"N-no, really, it's okay. It'll just make it harder for you to read... You don't have to worry about me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's fine. I can see it from here."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I can read it from here too, so don't worry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I insist."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, no, I insist."

The two of us continued pushing the textbook back and forth until the teacher at the front of the classroom cleared her throat softly.

Teacher
"You two over there. Please keep quiet."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"! S-sorry..."

We both froze and looked at each other.
I gave him a sheepish smile, and Ayumu-kun smiled back shyly.
...Ah, this feeling. There's something a little nostalgic about it.
(Go to the next chapter (Another path.))

Happy conclusion

...I have to thank him. He helped me, after all. I should at least say something.
"Gloomy."
"Poor Anesaki-san."
"Stay away from me."
Their snickering echoed in my head, and I felt like something was stuck in the back of my throat.
In the end, I couldn't even bring myself to utter the first syllable of "thank you."
I'm the worst.
(Go to the next chapter (Happy path.))

Another path

Chapter 4: Promise for tomorrow

As soon as the final homeroom ended, Kuraguchi-kun grabbed his things and left the classroom.
He was heading in the opposite direction from the school entrance. I wonder where he's off to. Perhaps he isn't going home just yet...?

Male student
"Anesaki-san! Can you help me with my studies?"
Female student
"I didn't understand today's math either!"

Several students gathered around me with their stationery in hand.
...I guess there's no helping it.
I held back a sigh and turned toward them with a smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure. What part?"
Male student
"The application problems from today—"
Male student
"Ohhh, I get it now! Thanks, Anesaki-san!"
Female student
"I get it too! Thanks!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're welcome. Anything else you want to ask about?"
Male student
"I'm good now."
Female student
"Me too!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If there's anything else you don't understand, just ask me anytime, okay?"
Male student
"Whoa! Anesaki-san, you're literally a goddess!"
Male student
"I'll be counting on you next time too!"
Female student
"Yeah, same here!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right then... I'm going home."
Male student
"Yeah! See ya!"
Female student
"Bye-bye!"

I waved to everyone and quickly made my way out of the classroom.
Aah... I'm beat. They held me up for a whole hour...
I know it's all part of keeping up the persona I've created, so I can't exactly complain, but having this happen so often is seriously getting exhausting.
I just want to hurry home and be comforted by Lord Wald...

Teacher
"Ah, Anesaki-san. Just the person I was looking for."
Nozomi Anesaki

"..."

I almost asked, "You're doing this on purpose, aren't you?"

Teacher
"Could you take these things to the study room in the library?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...The library study room. Understood."

I reminded myself that this, too, was part of maintaining my persona... and slowly made my way back along the path I had come.
The library was as unpopular as ever.
It had a bit of a lonely feel to it, but I actually found this much quiet pretty comforting.

Image:
Books in the study area may not be checked out!

I was on my way to the study room, my shoulders finally relaxing, when I suddenly felt someone's presence.
I immediately straightened up and looked inside.
Kuraguchi-kun was sitting at a desk, working on something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Kuraguchi-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?! A-Anesaki-san?!"

He quickly closed his books and notebook and got to his feet. Whatever he was doing, he clearly didn't want it seen.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Sorry... Did I interrupt you?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh, n-no, not really... I wasn't doing anything important..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What brings you here, Anesaki-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I've got an errand from the teacher."

I set the cardboard box I had been carrying in both hands down in the corner of the classroom.
Phew... That was pretty heavy.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...That sounds tough."
Nozomi Anesaki

"It happens pretty often, so I've gotten used to it."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"The teachers seem to trust you a lot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha... Yeah... I guess."

Well... I've been doing such a good job of staying on the teachers' good side, so of course they'd trust me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I've heard quite a few of the teachers talk about you, too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"They said you're the person to go to if there's ever a problem."

What is that supposed to mean...? Do they think I'm someone they can dump anything on?
I was honestly getting sick of being treated like this, but if everyone was going to rely on me, I had to live up to their expectations.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... if you ever need anything, just let me know. I'll help however I can."

I spoke with the confident air of a class representative, and Kuraguchi-kun responded with an awkward smile as he scratched his cheek.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm fine... So please, don't worry about me too much."

Could Kuraguchi-kun have figured out that I've been thinking about him all day...?
He said I shouldn't worry about him, but somehow, I just can't stop...
What do I even want my relationship with Kuraguchi-kun to be?
I don't want to get involved with him any more than I have to. I want to keep acting like we're strangers.
And yet, I can't bring myself to completely ignore him. I want to get closer to him.
Those contradictory thoughts have been constantly swirling around in my head.
I wonder what Kuraguchi-kun thinks.
Ever since I told him I wasn't the Nozomi he used to be close with, he seemed to be avoiding me.
Maybe he doesn't want to get close to "this version" of me. That thought left me with mixed feelings.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... well... I should get going."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yes, goodbye."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See you."

After all, I suppose keeping some distance between us was for the best.
With that thought in mind, I was about to leave, when...

Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way... is that book any good?"

...The thought of leaving things at that left me feeling a little empty, so I stopped and asked him that question.
I wasn't ready to go back to how things were between us, but... I did want to have a few more "fun" conversations with him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh..."

Kuraguchi-kun looked down at the light novel on his desk.
Then he turned back toward me with a strained smile.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... I-I guess....
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh... Maybe I'll give it a try too."

If Kuraguchi-kun likes it, I'm sure I'd probably enjoy it too. I remember that we had pretty similar tastes.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh... you're going to read it...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If it's good, I'd like to check it out."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well... I don't think it would really be your thing, though..."

...So that's what you think. That makes me a little sad.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But it's interesting, right?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Well, I think it is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Then I think I'll read it too. I wonder if they have it in the library."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...No, I don't think they do. It's still pretty new..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."

As I wondered whether I should buy it, Kuraguchi-kun gave me a doubtful look.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Are you really going to read it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. It looks interesting."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Um... well... I could lend it to you, if you want?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah! No, I mean... only if you need it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You'd lend it to me?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-yes... I don't have Volume 1 on me today, so... I could bring it tomorrow... Would that be okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure...! Thanks!"

It reminded me of the times I used to borrow books from Kuraguchi-kun, and I found myself feeling nostalgic again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, I'm going home."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Okay. ...See you tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, see you!"

I waved goodbye to Kuraguchi-kun as I left the study room, a little smile creeping onto my face.
"See you tomorrow," huh...
Back in our first year of middle school, we used to say that to each other every day.
Our relationship may be different now, but those parting words still felt just right.

Chapter 5: Crossing paths

Female student
"Morning, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning."
Male student
"Good morning, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."

After the usual exchange of greetings, I headed over to my seat.
Kuraguchi-kun looked up from his book and glanced my way.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

But he turned his attention back to his book without saying a word.
...Huh. He's not going to say hi...?
I set my bag down on my desk and called out to Kuraguchi-kun as I pulled out my chair.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ah, g-good morning..."

Kuraguchi-kun flinched and turned toward me.
Things were still... awkward. I could tell he was keeping his guard up around me.
Though I suppose I was doing the same thing... Still, if nothing else, I wanted us to be able to have a normal friendship.
Once I'd put my things away, I tried to be as friendly and approachable as possible when I spoke to him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, did you bring that novel we were talking about yesterday?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... you didn't bring it?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, I did... You actually want to read it...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...O-okay then."

Looking somewhat uneasy, Kuraguchi-kun pulled a package from his schoolbag.

Miho Orikasa
"MOOORNING, Nozomi!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa?! Miho...! You startled me...!"
Miho Orikasa
"Hm? Am I interrupting something?"

Miho looked back and forth between Kuraguchi-kun and me.

Kuraguchi-kun tucked the package back into his bag and immediately turned away.
It seemed like he wasn't comfortable talking with someone else around. I felt the same way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... No, not really..."

Miho Orikasa
"You sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"More importantly, are you feeling better?"
Miho Orikasa
"Good as new. Though I wouldn't have minded having a few more days off school."
Female student
"Oh, Miho's here! Are you all better now?"
Female student
"Pass your cold on to me!"

A lively crowd soon formed around me.
Kuraguchi-kun seemed to disappear into the background, quietly reading his book.
...I missed my chance to get that book from him. Surely I'd get to talk to him later, though.
Or so I thought...
In the end, I didn't get an opportunity to talk to Kuraguchi-kun before the final homeroom of the day.
During every break, people would quickly gather around me, and Kuraguchi-kun would leave the classroom.

Teacher
"Goodbye."
Students
"Goodbye."

After we said goodbye to the teacher, the classroom erupted into chatter.
If I was going to talk to him, this was my last chance.
I quickly looked over at Kuraguchi-kun, only to find him looking back at me, as if we'd coordinated it beforehand.
But then...

Male student
"Anesaki-saaan."

A male student who had appeared out of nowhere stood between Kuraguchi-kun's desk and mine.

Male student
"I wanted to ask you something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... is it about studying?"
Male student
"Yeah."
Female student
"I have a question too!"
Male student
"Me too, me too."

...Please, give me a break.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry... I have a student council meeting today..."
Male student
"Oh, right."
Female student
"Oh yeah, I forgot about that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... Maybe another time."
Male student
"Bummer."

Everyone gradually filed out of the classroom.
I breathed a quiet sigh of relief and glanced beside me, only to find that Kuraguchi-kun was already gone.
I hurriedly looked out in the hallway and caught sight of him walking away from the entrance, just like yesterday.
Could he be heading to the library again today? If today's meeting ends early, maybe I'll stop by.
Keeping that thought in mind, I made my way to the student council room.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Well then, I think that's all for today."
Secretary
"Good work, guys."
Treasurer
"Good work."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good work, everyone."

Today's student council work ended up taking exactly until the very last bell. Kuraguchi-kun must have gone home by now.
...*Sigh*... I never got the chance to talk to him after all...
Tomorrow's Saturday, so I won't get to see Kuraguchi-kun again until two days later...
As always, we, the student council members, decided to walk home together.
I temporarily parted ways with the seniors and headed for my shoe locker. And there, I found someone there I never expected to see.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Woah...! Anesaki-san?!"

Kuraguchi-kun turned around in surprise. He then stumbled backward, frantically waving both hands.

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"I-I wasn't trying to do anything weird or anything...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I was just thinking I'd put the book in your shoe locker..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"S-sorry...! You wouldn't want someone opening your shoe locker without permission...! But I haven't done anything yet...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no, no, wait, just calm down."

I smiled and moved closer, trying to calm Kuraguchi-kun down, who seemed to be panicking for no reason.
Kuraguchi-kun took another step back and looked at me anxiously.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm glad... that you haven't gone home yet, Kuraguchi-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We didn't really get a chance to talk today."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...That's true."

Kuraguchi-kun gave a faint, wry smile before adopting a more serious expression and offering me the bag.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Here... it's that book we were talking about yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I hope you enjoy it, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sure I will."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"

As Kuraguchi-kun tilted his head in confusion, I accepted the bag with a faint smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"So, then... um..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah..."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

A slightly awkward silence fell between us. I wasn't sure how to wrap up the conversation.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... Kuraguchi-kun... you're going home now, right?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... Ah, yes."

What should I do...? Since we'd come this far, perhaps I could ask him to walk home with me.
Or would that be crossing the line and getting too close?
And, for that matter, wouldn't I only be inconveniencing Kuraguchi-kun...?
While I was lost in this jumble of thoughts, footsteps began approaching from outside the school entrance.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Anesaki-san? Are you there? Is something wrong?"

Hoshina-senpai called out to me with a puzzled look on his face. He must have come to check on me since I hadn't come outside yet.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... well, I'll head home, then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"See you later."

Kuraguchi-kun spun around and hurried away.
...I guess it does make me feel a little lonely.

That night.
Before going to bed, I started reading the light novel I'd borrowed from Kuraguchi-kun. A few hours later, I turned the last page and let out a deep sigh.
It was really...
AMAZING!!!
I had planned to read it little by little, but I got completely absorbed and ended up reading the whole thing in one sitting.
Kuraguchi-kun and I really do have the same taste.
And I couldn't help feeling a little happy that, even now, that hadn't changed.
Seriously, though... This light novel was so good.
I'm dying to know what happens next... I want to read it already... Maybe I'll go buy the next volume tomorrow...
I wonder what Kuraguchi-kun would think if he found out I'd bought the next volume myself.
Would he find it strange...? I've been keeping up the persona of "Nozomi Anesaki," someone who's completely uninterested in otaku stuff, after all...
But... I just have to know what happens next...! I need to find out what happens with the childhood friend and the class rep...!

Yep. I'm definitely buying it tomorrow.

Chapter 6: Shared interests

And so, the very next day, I excitedly headed to the shopping mall.
I made sure to look around first before stepping into the light novel section.
I headed toward the back while searching for the book I wanted, and when I turned the corner at the end of the aisle…

Ayumu・Nozomi
"Ah..."

It was the last encounter either of us expected.
It was such a surprise that neither of us could react right away. We simply stared at each other in silence for a few seconds.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"Huuuuh...?"

Kuraguchi-kun and I both let out a startled cry at the same time.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Anesaki-san... Why are you here...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... well... no, you see... I..."

I came here to buy a light novel!
...Yeah, I probably shouldn't say that... Not with the persona I'm supposed to be keeping up.
But this is clearly the light novel section… Would "I was just browsing" really work as an excuse?
I glanced over at Kuraguchi-kun's hands. He was holding the newest volume of the series I was looking for.
...Oh, well.
Giving up on trying to hide it, I picked up one of the books stacked in front of Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I came to buy... this."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The book I borrowed from you was so, so interesting that... I just got curious about what happens next."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... you've already read it...? Wait, you actually thought it was interesting...? Really?"

Was it really that surprising? Kuraguchi-kun's dramatic reaction amused me so much that I let out a small laugh.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean it. It was so interesting, I just couldn't put it down."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Is that so...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. I wanted to read the rest right away, so I came to buy it."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"O-oh..."

Kuraguchi-kun nodded as if in a daze, and then his face softened into a faint smile.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I see... I'm glad you liked it..."

Ah... that smile. It was so very "Ayumu-kun."
A sense of nostalgia spread through my chest, making my heart flutter a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...W-wow, there are already four volumes out...!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm? Yes. The fifth one comes out next month."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really...? Well, since I'm here, I might as well get volumes two through four."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ahaha. They all end on such a cliffhanger—it's probably a good idea."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll do that."

Just as I reached for the remaining two books...

???
"Huh? Anesaki-san?"

I heard a voice from behind me and reflexively turned around.
Oh, crap... my classmates...!
I quickly put the light novel I was holding back on the shelf and put on my public face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-hey, everyone..."
Girl
"Nozomi, were you free today? We should've invited you!"
Boy
"Yeah, for real. But you always look so busy, we didn't want to bother you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha..."

Well, I would turn down their invitation anyway, because I'd rather stay at home...

Boy
"Uh... wait. Kuraguchi... right?"

One of the boys noticed Kuraguchi-kun and gave him a suspicious look.
He froze for a moment, then hurriedly stepped away from me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well then... um... goodbye."

Kuraguchi-kun bowed with a stiff, overly formal manner, and disappeared before I could even try to stop him.

Girl
"Huh? What was that just now?"
Boy
"Anesaki-san, why were you with Kuraguchi...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... um... I just happened to run into him..."
Boy
"Oh, okay. Thank goodness. I thought you were hanging out with him or something."
Girl
"Like that would ever happen."
Boy
"Yeah, exactly."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I wasn't lying. Kuraguchi-kun and I really did just happen to run into each other here.
...But I still felt uneasy.

Boy
"Wait... look at this. It's totally an otaku novel."
Girl
"Ahh, it really is. So moeee."
Everyone
"Moeee."

Everyone giggled as they looked at the light novel.
Feeling increasingly uncomfortable, I forced a smile and spoke up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I've got something to do, so I'm going home."
Girl
"Oh, really? We're just about to stop by a café. Can't you stay for a bit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... I need to go back right away."
Boy
"I see... What a shame."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, see you later."

I said a quick goodbye and quickly walked away.
The moment I stepped out of the bookstore, I let out a deep sigh.
I didn't even get to buy the books... I hardly got to talk to Kuraguchi-kun… On top of that, they made fun of light novels...
This is just awful... Ugh...
Most of all, I felt disgusted with myself for trying so hard to please everyone.

Chapter 7: Jealousy

After the weekend.
When I got to school, Kuraguchi-kun was quietly reading a book again, just like always.
No one paid any attention to him. It was as though they treated him like part of the background.
And this scene was already becoming an ordinary part of everyday life.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning, Kuraguchi-kun."

When I spoke to him, I noticed several people looking at me in surprise.
I even heard someone whisper, "That's Anesaki-san for you. She's so nice."
That's not what it's about... I protested inwardly as I took my seat.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good morning."

Kuraguchi-kun merely gave me a brief reply and resumed reading.
There was no opening for me to speak to him. A thick wall had been firmly put up between us.
Perhaps this was the limit of how far I could get with the "me" I was now...
The day passed in the blink of an eye.
After our morning greetings, I never found another chance to speak with Kuraguchi-kun. I couldn't even find the right moment to return the light novel I had borrowed from him.
Though... If I just wanted to return it, I could have done so at any time. All I had to do was say "thank you" and hand the book back.
But that alone wouldn't have satisfied me. I wanted to tell Kuraguchi-kun what I thought of the book.
I wanted to see how he would react.
That was why I wanted some time alone with him... but...
The bell rang, signaling the end of the school day.
While everyone in the class chatted away as they leisurely got ready to go home, Kuraguchi-kun quickly packed up his things and left the classroom.
Not a single person paid any attention to him. Perhaps they simply didn't care.
I swiftly packed my things into my bag, gave Miho a quick goodbye, and hurried after Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun."
As soon as I stepped into the hallway, I spotted Kuraguchi-kun ahead of me and called out to him.
He turned around at once, stopping as if he had been taken completely by surprise.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Yes...?"

I suddenly realized I had no idea what to say.
I'd followed after him on impulse, but this wasn't exactly a place where I could return the book and have a casual chat.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... aren't you going to the library today?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, I was planning to go straight home today... Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"In that case..."

Just as I was about to ask, "Want to walk home together?"...

Teacher
"Oh, Anesaki-san, could I have a word with you?"

The teacher came out of the classroom carrying a cardboard box. ...Here we go again...

Teacher
"Take this to the library for me, will you? You can just leave it in the corner of the study room."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."

I gave the expected reply. But honestly, though... He made it sound like "no" wasn't even an option.

Teacher
"Oh, but this is pretty heavy, so maybe I should get Kuraguchi-kun to help out, too."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"Huh?"
Teacher
"I think it'd be a bit much for one girl to handle alone... I mean, I'm actually having a pretty hard time with it myself right now."

The teacher gave an awkward laugh, his arms trembling as he held the box. Then why didn't you just ask one of the stronger-looking guys in the first place...?

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Then... uh... I'll carry it myself..."

Huh... Could Kuraguchi-kun really handle it...?
I felt bad for thinking it, but honestly, he didn't exactly look very strong.
Maybe the teacher was thinking the same thing, because he gave Kuraguchi-kun a skeptical look.

Teacher
"Are you sure you can handle it? It's really heavy."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I-I think I can..."
Teacher
"Be careful..."

Kuraguchi-kun carefully took the cardboard box from him, and...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...!"

He stumbled.
I instinctively reached out and steadied the cardboard box from the side.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you okay...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Y-yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think I'll help you carry it after all."
Teacher
"Yeah, that's probably for the best. You two can take it together."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Okay."

Kuraguchi-kun nodded without looking up, then repositioned the cardboard box so that he was facing me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay... let's go."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yes..."

We began walking, both of us paying attention to the other's pace.
As we did, a few students who had finished getting ready to leave the classroom came out and looked at us with surprise.

Female student
"Nozomi... is everything all right?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yeah, I'm fine."
Male student
"...Want me to help?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun's helping me, so I'm okay."
Male student
"Really...?"

I felt awkward beneath the gazes of everyone who seemed to have something they wanted to say, and hurried my steps a little.
Kuraguchi-kun silently followed my pace.
When we finally reached the quiet, deserted library, I felt a sense of relief.
Kuraguchi-kun also seemed a little more at ease.
After setting the cardboard box down in the corner of the study room, we both let out a sigh almost at the same time.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... I feel like I dragged you into this."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, I should be apologizing... Sorry I couldn't carry it on my own..."

He quietly added, "I'm so pathetic."

Nozomi Anesaki
"But I wanted to talk to you anyway, so this worked out nicely."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh...?"

I took the bag containing the book from my schoolbag and offered it to Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"This is the book I borrowed from you. Thanks."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, yeah... I see. Did you feel like you had to rush through it because of me? You could've taken your time..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. Like I said before, it was so much fun that I ended up reading it all in one sitting."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"The part where the childhood friend completely misunderstands the class rep is hilarious, don't you think?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Their misunderstanding in the middle had me on the edge of my seat."
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"...Y-yeah. I thought that whole part was really well put together. And I liked how the rival showed up after that, too."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Right?! And when the childhood friend basically gives the rival a veiled declaration of war—that was so good!"

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Ah, I like that scene too. It was such a fitting move for a childhood friend."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Yeah, exactly. It wasn't exactly a straightforward confrontation, but I thought it was really cool how they were still clearly trying to protect the class rep."

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"The class rep didn't realize what was going on though..."

Nozomi Anesaki

"I know! It was so frustrating! And the first volume ends with them still misunderstanding each other, right? I really want to know what happens next."

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Huh? You haven't started volume two yet?"

Nozomi Anesaki

"Ah... yeah... I didn't buy it in the end..."

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"I see. I actually have volumes two and three with me today. Do you want to borrow them?"

Nozomi Anesaki

"Really?! You don't mind?"

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Yes, of course. I'll probably finish volume four today, so I can lend you that one too."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Thanks! Ah... but if I binge all the way through volume four, I don't think I'll be able to stand waiting for volume five."

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Ahaha, I know what you mean. Volume four starts a whole new development... and it looks like it's going to end on another cliffhanger."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Oh, really? ...What kind of development?"

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Uh, that'd be a spoiler."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Just a tiny hint...!"

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Hmm... Well, the class rep dies at some point."

Nozomi Anesaki

"What… How does that happen?!"

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"You can look forward to finding out when you read it."

Nozomi Anesaki

"...Now I really want to know..."

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Ahaha. I'll lend it to you right after I finish it, so take your time reading it before volume five comes out."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Knowing me, I'll get too curious and just read the whole thing in one sitting..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Happens all the time."

I knew it... Kuraguchi-kun and I really are on the same wavelength. I was happy to get exactly the reaction I'd been hoping for.
As I took a moment to savor the nostalgia, Kuraguchi-kun suddenly looked at me with a serious look on his face.
The mood became slightly more solemn, and I found myself matching his expression.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's a little... unexpected."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"That you'd like this book so much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I guess so..."

I'm more surprised that you found it surprising... Oh, right... I'm just "Nozomi Anesaki" now, aren't I...
Then I wonder what would be the natural way to respond.
As I searched for something harmless to say, Kuraguchi-kun spoke up, looking somewhat lost in thought.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Somehow... it feels like I'm talking to Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

My heart skipped a beat. ...No, perhaps it was more of a chill.
I instinctively shrank back, and Kuraguchi-kun blinked as though suddenly coming to his senses.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"S-sorry... Pay no mind to that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's all right..."

The memory of "Nozomi-chan" still remains vivid within Kuraguchi-kun.
It's been over three whole years since then. I wonder if anything has changed for him during that time.
Curious to know the answer, I finally worked up the nerve to take a step forward.

Nozomi Anesaki
"So... 'Nozomi-chan' was... an old friend of yours, right, Kuraguchi-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Huh...? ...Y-yeah... I guess so..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What was she like?"

Even to me, it seemed like such a blatantly transparent pretense. It was a pretty underhanded way of going about it, too.
But Kuraguchi-kun didn't seem to suspect a thing. He gazed into the distance, his eyes just as pure and innocent as they had been back then.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Let's see... she was... a girl I really connected with..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"We'd talk every day... about the same kinds of things we're talking about now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Somehow, everything she said was exactly what I was thinking..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"And she always listened seriously to everything I had to say."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I had so much fun every day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ohh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...She's a very, very important friend to me."

Those simple words pierced my heart. I felt a little short of breath.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Even now?"

I asked timidly, and Kuraguchi-kun smiled and nodded without hesitation.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yes, even now. She's my one and only best friend."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I wish I could see her."

Kuraguchi-kun narrowed his eyes, as though lost in memories of the past.
It wasn't *my* image that reflected in his eyes.
The pain slowly spreading through my chest was a mixture of self-loathing, guilt, and jealousy toward my past self.
I was jealous of "Nozomi-chan," the girl Kuraguchi-kun still held so dear.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You know—"

That "Nozomi-chan" is me.
If only I could tell him that.
But I didn't have the courage to do so, and once again, I was painfully reminded of how despicable I was.
Kuraguchi-kun hasn't changed at all. He's exactly the same as he was back then, both in appearance and in who he is inside.
There were times when I resented him for not changing, but in the end, I'm glad he stayed the same Kuraguchi-kun.
And me?
...There's no point even asking.
I'd grown on the outside, but on the inside, I had been steadily regressing.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Anesaki-san?"

Kuraguchi-kun tilted his head in confusion as I fell silent.
In the end, I couldn't bring myself to say what I wanted to, so I gave him a faint, evasive smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you think... we could do this again sometime?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"*I* really enjoyed talking about books with you today, too..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Y-yeah... me too. I had fun."

Kuraguchi-kun smiled bashfully and took two books out of his bag.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Here. This is the rest."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-thank you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I'd… love to hear what you think when you're done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah...! I'll read them right away!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hahaha, really, take your time."

Kuraguchi-kun smiled and readjusted the bag in his hand.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well then, I should get going."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... yeah..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...See you tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... see you..."

Kuraguchi-kun left the library, leaving me alone in the quiet room.
Back when I was "Nozomi-chan," we would just go home together like it was the most natural thing in the world...
Will I ever be able to stand beside "Nozomi-chan" as the person I am now?
Once again, I was jealous of myself.

Chapter 8: A past beyond my reach

After that, Kuraguchi-kun and I began sharing little conversations like this more often.
But in the classroom, nothing really changed. We continued to keep our distance from each other.
Our interactions remained strictly formal, and on the surface, we were still nothing more than ordinary classmates.
It was only after school that we would let our conversations go a little deeper.
We were slowly getting into the habit of chatting in the empty library.
Lately, I've caught myself looking forward to coming to school for that very reason.
...Of course, that was probably just me. I still couldn't tell what Kuraguchi-kun made of it.
Even though we kept having the same kinds of conversations we'd had when I was "Nozomi-chan," Kuraguchi-kun still seemed to maintain a boundary between us.

Teacher
"And that's the end of homeroom. Stand."
Students
"Goodbye."

And with that, another week comes to an end.
Lately, I feel like each day has been passing by so quickly.
Maybe it's because I've started finding little things to look forward to in my school life that my days feel more fulfilling than they used to.
When I turned my gaze toward the seat beside me, Kuraguchi-kun, who had just finished putting his things into his bag, turned to face me.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

We smiled at each other.
It didn't really mean anything, but lately, whenever our eyes met, Kuraguchi-kun had started smiling at me.
It made me feel like we'd gotten closer, and I was a little happy about that.

Male student

"Anesaki-san, do you have a student council meeting today?"

A voice came from beside me, and I reflexively turned in its direction. At the same time, I caught Kuraguchi-kun looking away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I do."
Female student
"So I guess you won't be able to help me study today either..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... Sorry...? Can we do it another day?"
Male student
"That's what you aaalways say. You haven't had aaany time for us lately, Nozomi-chan."
Female student
"Give her a break. Nozomi's been pretty busy lately."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha... sorry..."

It's not that I'm really busy... I've just been spending time talking with Kuraguchi-kun in the library...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Anyway, I'd better head to the student council room."
Male student
"Okay, see you later. And I'm counting on you next week!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, next week."

...Maybe. I added in my head, before grabbing my bag and leaving the classroom.
Once I was in the hallway, I quietly glanced back into the room.
Kuraguchi-kun was, as always, quietly getting ready to go home by himself.
...I wonder what he's doing today.
It would be nice if I could talk to him for a little while after the student council meeting was over... but it's not like we'd actually made plans or anything...
He might not even go to the library today. And even if he did, he might leave before I finished my student council work.
After all, Kuraguchi-kun usually went to the library for his own reasons, not to talk with me.
He'd leave as soon as he'd finished what he came to do, and whenever he wanted some time to focus by himself, he'd gently hint that I should leave first.
That's why, to this day, I've never once gone home from school with Kuraguchi-kun.
To him, I was still only that important.

The student council meeting finished relatively quickly today. There was still quite a bit of time left before the school day ended.
After we all left the student council room together as usual, the treasurer suddenly spoke up as if a thought had just occurred to him.

Treasurer

"By the way, does anyone have anything planned after this?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Not really."
Secretary
"Me neither."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't have anything planned either."
Treasurer
"Why don't we stop somewhere on the way home for a change? We're always just talking about boring school stuff."
Secretary
"Yeah, you're right. Even though we've known each other for forever, we never really hang out outside of school, do we?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"True. How about we grab some tea before heading home?"
Treasurer･Secretary
"Sounds good!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"What do you think, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um..."

What should I do...? The opportunity to have tea with Hoshina-senpai is incredibly tempting, but...
.....

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry, I just remembered I have something to take care of, so I'll excuse myself here."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, is that so?"
Treasurer･Secretary
"What a shame."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Would you invite me again sometime?"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Of course. Let's all go together another time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you. Well then, I'll be going."

I turned around and quickened my pace a little.
...I wonder if Kuraguchi-kun is in the library.
I'd be happy if I could talk to him, even just for a little while, so I decided to at least take a peek inside.
I gently opened the library door, trying not to make a sound.
I slipped one foot inside and cautiously looked around.
.....
...It was really quiet. There wasn't a sound, and I couldn't sense anyone else around. The lights weren't even on.

I suppose Kuraguchi-kun really has gone home already.
...Huh... What is this feeling? Why am I so shaken?
Had I been expecting him to be there—or, more than that, had I simply been certain he would be?
Maybe, somewhere deep inside, I'd allowed myself to believe that Kuraguchi-kun would be waiting for me.
But of course that was not going to happen... I'm the only one looking forward to our conversations after all...
Deeply disappointed, I turned around and reached for the library door.
...Just then, I thought I heard a faint noise coming from somewhere in the back of the library.
I stopped and strained my ears. ...Nothing. It's still quiet .
No chair scraping against the floor, no rustle of turning pages, no sound of someone writing.
Still, just to be sure... I quietly headed toward the back of the library.
It doesn't look like anyone's there...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah."

I stepped into the study room and couldn't help but let out a small gasp.
The person I thought I'd missed was there after all.
He was lying face-down on the desk, completely motionless. Apparently, he was asleep.
I slowly approached Kuraguchi-kun, walking on tiptoe.
When I got close enough to reach out and touch him, I could hear his soft breathing.
He showed no signs of waking up.
I stopped and crouched down where I stood.
Then I turned around slightly and leaned over to take a peek at Kuraguchi-kun's face.
With his long bangs swept aside, I could finally see the face that was usually hidden behind them.
...Hmm... Yeah, it really was Ayumu-kun... He looked so much more grown-up now, but I could still clearly see the boy he'd been back in his first year of middle school.
I lifted my head and looked at my reflection in the window.
...I've really changed, haven't I? It feels like there's hardly anything left of the girl I used to be.
Back then I was frumpy and awkward, but Ayumu-kun had been friendly with me without caring about any of that.
A feeling of nostalgia welled up inside me, and I peered at Kuraguchi-kun's sleeping face once again.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...!"

At that very moment, Kuraguchi-kun opened his eyes.
I didn't have time to back away, and suddenly we were staring straight at each other, practically nose to nose.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun blinked rapidly…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan?!"

…and sprang up dramatically.
Then he blinked several more times.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... Ohh, Anesaki-san..."

Kuraguchi-kun's eyes finally focused clearly on me.
I'd gotten a little jolt when he'd called me "Nozomi-chan" earlier, but it seemed he'd just been groggy from sleep.

Nozomi Anesaki
"M-morning..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah... Good morning..."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Wait, Anesaki-san?!"

Kuraguchi-kun sprang upright again. It seemed he was finally fully awake now.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Why are you here...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The student council meeting finished early, so I decided to come by."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm glad you haven't gone home yet, Kuraguchi-kun."

I knew he hadn't been waiting for me, of course, but I was still happy that we got to talk again today.
Kuraguchi-kun gave me a blank look, then glanced up at the clock on the wall.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... It's gotten pretty late already..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... I must've fallen asleep while I was waiting..."

...Hm? While you were waiting...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Kuraguchi-kun, what were you waiting for?"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? ...Ah."

Kuraguchi-kun suddenly covered his mouth. A faint blush colored his cheeks.
Could it be...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Were you waiting... for me?"

The question sounded awfully presumptuous, and my voice grew quieter at the end.
Kuraguchi-kun's face turned even redder as he frantically shook his head.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"N-no, that's not what I meant! It's not like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... so you weren't..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"?! No! That's not...! I mean, not... not exactly..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I... I wasn't counting on you coming, Anesaki-san..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I just hoped you would... just a little..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I-it's not like I would've minded if you hadn't come..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Wait, no. I did want you to come..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, that's not it...! A-anyway, I didn't want you to feel like you had to come because of me."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So even if you hadn't come, of course I wouldn't have thought any less of you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Pfft."

I was desperately trying to hold back my laughter. Kuraguchi-kun's frantic attempts to explain himself were pretty funny.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh, A-Anesaki-san... is something wrong...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well... you were waiting for me, right...?"

I asked him again.
Kuraguchi-kun paused for a moment before giving an awkward nod, as if he'd finally given in.
A soft warmth spread through my chest.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I was hoping I'd find you here, Kuraguchi-kun."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I have so many things I want to talk to you about."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Yeah. Me too."

We exchanged embarrassed smiles and once again began chatting about all sorts of little things no one else knew about.

Some time later, the sound of a chime echoed through the quiet classroom.
Startled, we stopped talking and simultaneously glanced at the clock.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Is it already this late?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Apparently."

Maybe it's because we got so caught up in our chat today, but the time just seemed to fly by. We were right in the middle of an interesting conversation, so it feels like a shame to stop here.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well then... I'll take care of cleaning up and locking up, so you can head home first, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"See you on Monday."

He waved me off so casually that it only made me more reluctant to leave.
Could he really not want to go home with me?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'll help you lock up."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, no, it's okay. It'll be quick, and there's really nothing I need to help with."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll wait for you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why don't we go home together?"

I mustered up the courage to ask him. Kuraguchi-kun looked surprised and stared intently at me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Uh... together...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah. You walk to school, right, Kuraguchi-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"That's right, but... don't you have someone to go home with, Anesaki-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Everyone from the student council already went home. My other friends either bike home or have club activities, so I didn't have anything planned with them."

Sometimes I walk home with Shun, but usually I go home alone.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...But... are you sure this is okay...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I mean, going home with you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...? You don't want to go home with me?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No! I do! I don't mind at all..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... let's go."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Okay."

Kuraguchi-kun finally smiled at me. Things are still a little awkward, but I feel like we've taken a step forward.

After locking up the library, I headed out into the hallway with Kuraguchi-kun.
I looked down at the school grounds through the window and spotted students tidying up after club activities.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun seems restless. I wonder what's wrong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you forget something?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No... not really."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you sure?"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Yeah."

Kuraguchi-kun nodded, looking somewhat absentminded.
He still seemed restless, and somehow that made me feel uneasy too... or maybe I was just getting nervous.
Um... right. I should talk about something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"About what you were saying earlier..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh? Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That book you said was interesting... I'd like to read it too."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...If you really want to, I can lend it to you. I just don't know if you'd enjoy it, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"From what you've told me, I think it'll be right up my alley."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ahaha... I don't know about that. It's a pretty eccentric story... and it's not exactly aimed at girls..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But if you think it's interesting, then I want to give it a try."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun fell quiet, wearing an expression I couldn't quite read. Did I say something weird?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Say, Anesaki-san..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Why are you... so kind to me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

It was the last question I ever expected. Because honestly, I don't remember being particularly kind to Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't know... I'm just acting normally."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Is that so? I think you're really kind, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"...Because... I've never had anyone talk to me like this before."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What about 'Nozomi-chan'?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You used to talk to 'Nozomi-chan' like this too, right?"

I had a feeling my words had come out a little sharper than intended.
But Kuraguchi-kun didn't seem to notice. A gentle look crossed his face as he narrowed his eyes and nodded.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then... me talking to you like this isn't anything strange, is it?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hmm... but... it's not quite the same."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What do you mean?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Being kind or not... that wasn't what mattered..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Because she was special."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

A brief, sharp pain shot through my chest.
Something indescribable welled up from the back of my throat, and I was seized by the urge to spit it out.
But instead, what escaped my lips was a faint laugh that sounded almost like a sneer.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Anesaki-san...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Pfft… sorry... it's nothing."

I bit down on my lip, desperately trying to hold back my laughter, but the whole thing was just too ridiculous.
"Nozomi-chan" was someone incredibly precious to Kuraguchi-kun.
His unwavering faith in their friendship has painted her in an overly idealized light.
So much so that he couldn't even entertain the slightest doubt that the person standing before him was that very "Nozomi-chan."
...What would Kuraguchi-kun think if he learned the truth?

Part of me wanted him to find out. And yet, the more I thought about it, the more frightening the prospect became.
The truth was, I still wasn't ready for it.
I wasn't ready to face Kuraguchi-kun as "Nozomi-chan" and treat him the same way I had back then.
Ultimately, I guess I care about myself above all else.
I'm the kind of person who could even cast aside my one and only best friend if it meant protecting myself.
...Who I am now is a far cry from the "Nozomi-chan" Kuraguchi-kun has built up in his mind.
And I was afraid of how disappointed he'd be when he finally learned the truth.

Normal end: Your ideal version of me

Before I knew it, we'd reached the school entrance without saying another word.
I wanted to say something, anything, but the words died before they reached my lips. A strange emptiness had taken hold of me.
Kuraguchi-kun didn't make any attempt to speak either.
We were finally walking home together, yet the mood was utterly dull.

Female student
"Oooh, it's Nozomi!"

Someone suddenly called out my name from behind.
When I turned around, I saw a group of my classmates making their way toward us.

Male student
"Anesaki-san, are you heading home now? You had a student council meeting today, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. Did you guys just finish club activities?"
Female student
"Yep, yep. I'm sooo tired."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, good work today."
Female student
"Oh, right! Nozomi, you got time?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Female student
"We were just talking about grabbing something at MOSDO* on the way home."
*Collaboration between MOS Burger and Mister Donut.
Male student
"If you're free, Nozomi-chan, come hang out with us."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... well..."

I happened to glance toward Kuraguchi-kun, who was standing beside me.
Apparently, that was when my classmates noticed him for the first time. They all looked at him with puzzled expressions.

Oh no.
I instinctively feigned indifference and moved away from Kuraguchi-kun.
Then, almost instantly, I was hit by a crushing wave of self-loathing. I was stunned by what I'd done.
...I'm the worst.
I was the one who had invited him to walk home with me in the first place, yet I'd turned around and openly pushed him away.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun didn't react at all. He simply put on his shoes in silence.
Without so much as glancing in my direction, he walked out of the entrance, acting as though we had nothing to do with each other.
And suddenly, I understood exactly why he'd been keeping his distance from me.
Because I was doing the very same thing to him.
I couldn't chase after him. I could only stand there in a daze.
Even now, I was putting my own self-preservation before anything else.

Male student
"...So, Nozomi-chan, what do you say?"

The conversation resumed as though nothing had happened. Everyone had already forgotten about Kuraguchi-kun.

Female student
"Let's go to MOSDO!"
Female student
"Oh, right! You can help us study at MOSDO!"
Male student
"Oh, that's actually a great idea. We can hang out at the MOSDO by the station for a while."
Female student
"Yeah, yeah! Sounds good!"

Cheerful voices echoed faintly from somewhere in the distance.
Going to MOSDO with them wasn't what I wanted.
I wanted to walk home with Kuraguchi-kun.
...So what am I doing…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... actually, I have somewhere I need to be, so I'm leaving now...!"
Male student
"Huh, really?"
Female student
"Aww, that's too bad."
Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry... Maybe next time...!"

I bowed apologetically to my classmates, who all looked disappointed, and hurried out of the entrance.
I quickly scanned the area ahead, but Kuraguchi-kun was nowhere to be seen in the courtyard.
I rushed through the school gate and out onto the street.
Then I caught sight of him a short distance ahead, walking away. I planted my foot and took off after him with all my strength.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun...!"

Kuraguchi-kun turned around and stopped.
I gradually slowed down and came to a stop right in front of Kuraguchi-kun.
He looked bewildered.
Unable to think of anything to say, I could only stand there in silence, struggling to catch my breath.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What's wrong?"

His voice was gentle. He seemed completely unbothered by the way I had treated him earlier.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I... thought maybe we could walk home together..."

The moment I said it, I felt ashamed. I'd rejected him once already. How selfish of me to say something like that.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...You really are so kind, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

I couldn't believe my ears.
If he'd called me cold, I would've understood. But kind? There was no way I could make sense of that.
For a moment, I wondered if he was being sarcastic. But Kuraguchi-kun's eyes were completely sincere.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Really... you don't have to worry about me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm used to being by myself... and I know it's my own fault that I can't fit in at school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm happy that you care about me, Anesaki-san, but I don't want to become a burden to you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So you don't have to force yourself to keep me company."

Though he had put it in a roundabout way, it was still a clear rejection.
And behind it were resignation, restraint, and above all, consideration for me.
Memories of the past came rushing back like a kaleidoscope, overwhelming me with emotion.
I think that back then, we were what each other needed.
Not for each other's sake, but because we each genuinely wanted the other in our lives.
We were equals.
But I don't think we can ever have that same kind of relationship again.
So long as I keep looking down on Kuraguchi-kun, we can't.
Still, there was one thing I wanted to set straight.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ayumu-kun."

When I called him by that familiar old name, Ayumu-kun's eyes widened in surprise.
I could tell he was looking for some remnant of the "Nozomi-chan" he remembered in the girl standing before him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not kind at all."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I wasn't with you just because I was being nice."

If I were really a kind person, I'd be able to put others first and act with their feelings in mind.
But that's not who I am. I only ever think about myself.
And the reason I stayed with Ayumu-kun was a very simple one.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's because I have fun when I'm with you, Ayumu-kun."

It was really as simple as that. There was no ulterior motive whatsoever.
I wasn't trying to look after Ayumu-kun just because he'd become isolated from the rest of the class.
Nor was I forcing myself to spend time with him.
His feelings had nothing to do with it.

I went to the library every day after school because it was something I wanted for myself. I was simply satisfying my own desire.
This feeling, at least, is no different from what I felt back when I was "Nozomi-chan." I'm certain of that.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Ayumu-kun just stared at me, seemingly at a loss for words.
I grew a little nervous, and it felt as though my hands and feet were going numb.
For a while, neither of us said a word. Then Ayumu-kun finally narrowed his eyes, his expression gentle.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I see."

Ayumu-kun smiled. He looked genuinely happy, as if he were fondly reminiscing about the past.
It was exactly what I'd hoped for, but seeing it made my chest ache, and I looked away.
What my reaction meant was obvious, yet the gentle look on Ayumu-kun's face remained unchanged.
I suppose Ayumu-kun will always see Nozomi-chan as the girl she was back then.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Can we keep talking like this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Will you come see me in the library again?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. Every day."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Next time, let's talk about your favorite books again."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry."

I forced the words out in a voice that was almost a groan. Ayumu-kun continued to smile gently.

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"...See you on Monday, then, 'Anesaki-san.' "

With that, he turned his back on me and walked away without looking back.
I think Ayumu-kun understood everything, and accepted that we would continue on like this.
Nothing had been taken from me. Everything important to me was already within my grasp.
And yet, the hollow sense of loss, as though there were a gaping hole in my chest, never faded.

Happy path

Chapter 4: Self-loathing

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Pass the sauce."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"Thanks."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"I ate the pudding that was in the fridge."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Did you know that they announced a sequel to 'My Noble Prince☆'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wait, really?!"
Shun Anesaki
"...So this is the only thing that gets a reaction out of you..."

Shun's expression was tense.
That was when I finally came to my senses. Come to think of it, I don't remember much after sitting down for dinner.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...So is that true?"
Shun Anesaki
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"They're really making a sequel to WataPuri?"
Shun Anesaki
"No... Do you honestly think I'd find out about that before you, Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Tch. So you were lying..."
Shun Anesaki
"She seriously just clicked her tongue at me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about the pudding?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? You actually heard that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I heard you."
Shun Anesaki
"Whoa... Seriously?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...So you really did it."
Shun Anesaki
"...I'll buy some tomorrow, ma'am."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Good."
Shun Anesaki
"Anyway..."

When Shun put down his chopsticks, the mood suddenly became more serious.

Shun Anesaki
"Did something happen? You were acting weird yesterday too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, nothing."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm... You sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Well, if you say so..."

Shun may have no sense of tact, but when it comes to reading people, he's almost as good as a love interest in an otome game.
He's always there to listen without making a big deal of it, and he'll cheer you up just as casually
What would Shun say if I told him about Kuraguchi-kun?
Would he tell me to become his friend, just like last time?
I suppose you have to be a born social butterfly to be able to suggest something like that so effortlessly.
...I'm not like Shun. With me, a single loose thread is enough to bring about consequences that can never be undone.
No matter how nicely I keep up appearances, underneath it all, I'm still a third-rate person.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Thanks for the meal."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah... Wait, you barely ate any of it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can have it."
Shun Anesaki
"I don't want it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll eat it tomorrow morning."
Shun Anesaki
"What about the pear? You don't want that either?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll have that tomorrow, too."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm..."

Shun looked like he wanted to say something, but he remained silent, so I turned away and left the living room.

10:00 PM.
Right on schedule, I had finished all of my preparation for the next day.
I had another hour I could spend playing games. I thought perhaps Lord Wald could soothe my weary heart.
I reached out for my game console… but for some reason, I withdrew my hand.
I'm not really feeling it. I don't think I could match that kind of energy right now.
Maybe I should play a different game...
I pulled the storage box of otome games I kept hidden in my closet.
I glanced over the titles, but the mere sight of them made me feel a bit nauseous.
No. I'm not in the mood to immerse myself in an otome game right now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun—"
Shun Anesaki
"Whoa?!"

The moment I opened the door, Shun jumped in surprise.

Shun Anesaki
"What the heck?! Ever heard of knocking?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, sorry. I forgot."
Shun Anesaki
"...You've gotta be kidding me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I said I'm sorry. ...Were you doing something?"
Shun Anesaki
"No... Not really."

Muttering something under his breath, Shun slipped the erotic maga—nope, just a regular music magazine he was holding back onto the shelf.

Shun Anesaki
"...What do you want?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Say... wanna play a game?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? A game... an otome game?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. I can lend you one if you want to play, though."
Shun Anesaki
"Ugh, no thanks. ...So what game are we talking about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You've got a bunch of games, don't you? Let's pick one we can battle each other in."
Shun Anesaki
"...Why all of a sudden?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"I just feel like beating the crap out of someone to blow off some steam."
Shun Anesaki
"Me? Okay then, bring it on."

Shun was really getting into it. Watching him, I found myself thinking, This is such a guy thing.

Shun Anesaki
"What do you want to play? A fighting game? A falling-block puzzle game?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Anything's fine. Even better if there are some handsome guys in it."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm... Then how about this one?"

Shun pulled out a game. It was a military-themed action game.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... these are supposed to be the handsome guys…?"
Shun Anesaki
"I think they look cool."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*. Whatever. Fine, we'll play this."

I sat down beside Shun and picked up a controller.

Shun Anesaki
"It's been a while since we played a game together, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, it has."

It must have been about a year since the last time. Then again, I could probably count on one hand the number of times I've ever played games with Shun.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis, have you played games like this before? If not, I can give you a head start."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I have."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? You have?!"

It must have really caught Shun off guard, because he tore his eyes away from the TV and turned toward me.
I kept my eyes fixed on the screen, lost in memories of the past.
These days, I'm more into otome games, but I used to play action games all the time.
And whenever I did, there was always one boy sitting beside me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Back when I was in my first year of middle school."

After hesitating for a moment, I finally spoke. In the end, I decided to tell Shun about Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"There was a boy I was pretty close with."
Shun Anesaki
"...First year of middle school… That was before you and I met, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. Back when I was still Nozomi Kimura."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm... And?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Honestly, he was the only friend I had back then. ...You probably could have guessed that, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Ahh... Though, I didn't know you actually had friends."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You really slipped a nasty comment in there like it was nothing... But yeah, I had one. Only one."
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh... What was he like?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...He was a lot like me."

Chapter 5: My very first friend

When I had just started middle school, I didn't have any friends.
The reason was pretty obvious. I looked and acted like a complete otaku.
I let my hair grow out without bothering to take care of it. I never paid any attention to how I looked to other people, and I was always sitting in the classroom reading paperback novels.
It's such a shameful chapter of my past that remembering it makes me squirm.
At the time, I agonized over why I couldn't make friends, but now, I don't find it strange at all.
With the way I was back then, it was only natural that I couldn't make any friends.
There was another boy in my class who was pretty much in the same situation.
He kept his face hidden behind his long bangs and spent his breaks reading alone.
That was Ayumu Kuraguchi-kun.
At first, Ayumu-kun and I barely acknowledged each other and we each kept to ourselves.
We didn't exactly gravitate toward each other just because we were both outsiders—especially since we were a boy and a girl.
But one day, during an integrated-studies class…

Teacher
"Today, we're doing introductions. Please form pairs."
Nozomi Kimura
(...Pairs... *Sigh*...)
Nozomi Kimura
(Is there anyone who might actually want to work with me...?)

Female student
"Wanna do it together?"
Female student
"Suuure."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
(Yeah... I didn't think so.)
Teacher
"Oh...? Kimura-san, you don't have a partner?"
Nozomi Kimura
"...No."
Teacher
"Well, that won't do... Oh, I know. Why don't you work with Kuraguchi-kun?"
Nozomi Kimura
"Uh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Teacher
"That's okay with both of you, right?"
Ayumu・Nozomi
"...Yes."

That was the first time Kuraguchi-kun and I actually interacted.
While everyone else paired up with someone of the same gender, the two of us stood out as the only boy-girl pair.

Nozomi Kimura
(This sucks... I can't believe I have to pair up with a boy...)
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
(And he hasn't said a word this whole time... Then again, neither have I...)
Nozomi Kimura
(*Sigh*... This is depressing... I just want to go home...)
Teacher
"Does everyone have a handout?"
Teacher
"Talk to your partner and fill in the blanks on the paper. You'll all have to present your answers afterward."
Teacher
"Okay, you can get started."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
(He won't say anything... What am I supposed to do...? We have to present this later...)
Teacher
"Huh? Kimura-san, Kuraguchi-kun. You haven't filled in a single thing. Make sure you actually do the assignment, okay?"
Nozomi Kimura
"...Ah, okay..."
Nozomi Kimura
(That's easy for you to say...)
Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
"...Hello."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hello."
Nozomi Kimura
(Ah... Thank goodness... At least he answered me...)
Nozomi Kimura
"...Um... I'm Nozomi Kimura..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I'm Ayumu Kuraguchi."
Nozomi Kimura
"Kuraguchi-kun... Um... When is your birthday...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...It's July 23rd."
Nozomi Kimura
"...What's your blood type?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Type A."
Nozomi Kimura
(This feels so mechanical... What's the point of asking him all this...?)
Nozomi Kimura
(Oh, well... What's the next one...?)
Nozomi Kimura
"What are your hobbies?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Reading... I guess."
Nozomi Kimura
(Reading, huh... That figures. Kuraguchi-kun is always reading a book. I wonder what kind of books he likes...)
Nozomi Kimura
(Maybe I should ask… It looks like we're supposed to give a more detailed answer for this one, anyway...)
Nozomi Kimura
"...What kind of books do you like?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"...Uh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Natsume Sōseki... I guess..."
Nozomi Kimura
(...Ohh... Pretty highbrow...)
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...A-and..."
Nozomi Kimura
"...Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…The 'Grade X' series…"

Looking back, this was the moment Ayumu-kun and I truly met, in every sense that mattered.

Nozomi Kimura
("Grade X"... ? That's...)
Nozomi Kimura
"From Shogeki Bunko*...?"
*Likely a reference to Dengeki Bunko, the real Japanese light-novel imprint.
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh...? Kimura-san, do you know it...?"
Nozomi Kimura
"I haven't read it, but... is it good?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-yeah, it's good. It's mostly focused on battles, but I think it's something girls can enjoy too."
Nozomi Kimura
"Really...? Maybe I'll give it a try."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... If you want, I could lend it to you..."
Nozomi Kimura
"Huh, seriously? I'd love that."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ah, haha... Um, Kimura-san... Do you also like this kind of books...?"
Nozomi Kimura
"Y-yeah... I do. I like manga and anime more than novels, though."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I see. I like manga and anime too. What have you been watching lately?"
Nozomi Kimura
"Right now, I'm really into 'Magical Girl Spica.' "
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, I love that one too. It's really good, isn't it?"
Nozomi Kimura
"I know, right?! So good!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You know, I'm also a big fan of 'Magical Earth.' It's the same type of thing."
Nozomi Kimura
"Ohh! I absolutely love that one! The finale was amazing!"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, it was great! I even went to see the movie in theaters."
Nozomi Kimura
"Me too! The movie was really good, too."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I still rewatch it every now and then."
Nozomi Kimura
"Wow... Now I kind of want to watch it again too. It's been a while."

Only three minutes after we first spoke, Ayumu-kun and I had already completely opened up to each other.
We clicked so naturally that it felt like we'd already been friends for years.
I had never once talked about my interests with someone and felt truly understood.
Yet with Ayumu-kun, every single word I said seemed to reach him exactly as I meant it.
And I understood everything he said just as easily. Everything he said resonated deeply with me.
I was so happy.
It was the first time I'd ever experienced the joy of sharing the same interests and conversations with another person.

Teacher
"Okay, that's all. Is everyone finished?"
Teacher
"...Huh?"
Teacher
"Kimura-san, Kuraguchi-kun... You haven't written anything down."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"...Sorry."
Ayumu・Nozomi
(But...)

We exchanged a glance and stifled a laugh.
The blanks on our worksheets were almost entirely empty, but by then, I understood Ayumu-kun in a way that a mere handful of lines on a worksheet never could have captured.
And somehow, I knew that Ayumu-kun understood me just as well.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's pretty much how Ayumu-kun and I became friends."
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh... Yeah, I can totally picture it. Sounds like you two were really hitting it off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, we were... pretty much."

Thinking back on it makes my cheeks feel a little warm.
To be honest, we were pretty embarrassing back then.
We both looked like a mess. We stuck out like sore thumbs in our class, and people probably thought we were weird.
But still...

Nozomi Anesaki
"It was fun... Really, really fun..."

From that day on, I started spending my breaks with Ayumu-kun.
Whenever we had to work in pairs, I'd choose him without hesitation.
Before long, we were regularly going over to each other's houses, too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I used to play action games like this with Ayumu-kun all the time, too."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah... I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So I don't need a head start."
Shun Anesaki
"Got it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"So..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"What happened to that Ayumu-kun guy? What's he doing now?"

Now...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...He's in my class."
Shun Anesaki
"...Whaat?"

Shun stopped moving.
I took advantage of the opening and started mashing the button. Two hits.

Shun Anesaki
"! Whoa, wait! That's not fair!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehe... Don't underestimate me."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah... Damn it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...But how did he end up in your class? What you were talking about happened before you moved here, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. Well... I was pretty surprised myself. He transferred here... recently."

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Shun froze again. I tossed a grenade.

Shun Anesaki
"Waaah!!! That hurts! Stop it!"

Shun's character staggered behind the tent, smoke pouring off him. ...This game is actually kind of fun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You remember how I bumped into that guy in front of the school yesterday?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm? Uh... hmm, yeah..."

Perhaps Shun didn't want to take any more damage, as he now seemed much more focused on the game.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That guy... turned out to be Ayumu-kun."
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh... Huh? ...Ah... Oh, that guy..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"...Wait, seriously?"

I tossed a second grenade.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, I missed."
Shun Anesaki
"Haha! Take that!"

...Crap.

Shun Anesaki
"...Seriously? He transferred here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I was so surprised. I couldn't believe a coincidence like that could actually happen."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Good for you."

Shun murmured under his breath. For an instant, I nearly froze, but somehow managed to keep myself from stopping.
That was a close one. I had the upper hand at the moment. I couldn't let anything slip and give myself away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...'Good for you'...? Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Why? I mean, anyone would be happy to run into an old friend, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... yeah, but... it's not that simple in my case..."
Shun Anesaki
"? What do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ayumu-kun hasn't changed at all. He's still exactly the same as he was back then."
Shun Anesaki
"...Oh, you mean he's still an otaku?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, exactly."

The light novel I picked up after we bumped into each other yesterday, the "Grade X" series he was trying to borrow from the library...
Everything pointed to the same conclusion: Ayumu-kun was still an otaku.

Shun Anesaki
"But you're an otaku too, Sis."

...Well, he's not wrong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But, you know... I at least manage to keep it hidden at school, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"I guess so. 'The brilliant, beautiful vice president'... You've got everyone fooled."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Exactly. So... I don't think I can talk to Ayumu-kun the way I used to, with my otaku side completely out in the open..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm... I see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

We stayed tucked behind our walls, neither of us daring to move. The air was thick with an odd sense of tension.

Shun Anesaki
"Well..."

Shun's character cautiously peeked his head out. Hmm... I can't get a shot from here.

Shun Anesaki
"Does it really matter?"

A rifle shot came flying at me. It clipped my leg, taking off a little of my health.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...What do you mean?"
Shun Anesaki
"I mean, why not just talk to him like you used to? You don't have to worry about all that other stuff."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can't. Then everyone will find out I'm an otaku."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. So? I don't see the problem."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha... What are you talking about? I'm Nozomi Anesaki, remember? I'm the brilliant, beautiful vice president! I'm at the top of the school social hierarchy!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."

Bullets have been occasionally grazing me for a while now. Damn... Where is Shun even shooting me from?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Either way, I can't let people find out I'm an otaku. They'll think I'm weird, and my whole school life will fall apart."
Shun Anesaki
"Really? I think you'd be fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nope. Absolutely not."
Shun Anesaki
"But you enjoy talking to him, don't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"You wanna talk about otaku stuff with him again, like you used to, right?"

Like we used to...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Did you see 'Magical Girl Spica' yesterday?"
Nozomi Kimura
"I did, I did! That was such a crazy twist!"

Ah... Those really were good times.

Once I started talking to Ayumu-kun, my boring school life became so much more fun.
So when I found out I was going to transfer schools, I was crushed. The thought that I wouldn't be able to talk to Ayumu-kun anymore made the world seem to go dark.
But there was nothing I could do. I moved away during the winter break of my first year of middle school.
As I struggled to adjust to my new surroundings, I became too wrapped up in my own problems to think about anything else.
Before long, I lost touch with Ayumu-kun.
Little by little, I forgot about the past. I started telling myself that I needed to move on and make a new life for myself.
But deep down, I hadn't changed at all.
The moment I saw Ayumu-kun again...
I was shocked and anxious, but more than anything, my heart was pounding with joy.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah... I guess it would be really fun if we could talk like we used to."

I'd told Ayumu-kun, "Stay away from me."
And yet, the truth was that I wanted to talk with him about all kinds of things. I wanted us to share our interests again, just like we had before.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But... I shouldn't... right...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean, just imagine this. Everyone at school will find out I'm an otaku..."
Shun Anesaki
"Mm-hm."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You'd hate that too, wouldn't you?"

Shun stopped moving.
I froze too.
Even though we were both within range of each other, neither of us made a move.

Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"I don't really mind."

Shun just shook his head.

Shun Anesaki
"If that's what you want, Sis."
Shun Anesaki

"I don't have a problem with it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun."

I took my eyes off the screen and turned toward Shun.
He silently turned toward me too.
And then I...
...fired a rocket launcher.

Shun Anesaki
"Wai—?! Huh? Heeeey!"

Shun's character was blown to pieces.
I stared at the words "YOU WIN" on the screen and grinned.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I win."
Shun Anesaki
"No, no way, no way! That doesn't count!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, it does, it totally counts. I played by the rules."
Shun Anesaki
"Dammit! One more! Come on, let's do one more!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Pass. I'm going to sleep."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?! No! You're not going to bed yet!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If I don't go to bed soon, it'll be bad for my skin. Besides, you're too weak."
Shun Anesaki
"W-wait... Just one more round, please..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nooope! Good niiiight! Bye-byeee!"

I waved to Shun, who was sitting there with his head hanging in defeat, and left the room.
...For some reason, I felt a little refreshed.
Maybe tomorrow, when I see Kuraguchi-kun, I'll try saying hello, at least.

Chapter 6: Absence

The next day, I arrived at school as usual, then stopped in front of the classroom door just like I had yesterday.
...Why am I so nervous? All I have to do is make eye contact and say, "Good morning."
...Okay.

Miho Orikasa
"Morning, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-whoa?! M-Miho!"
Miho Orikasa
"Ahaha, you're as funny as ever."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez... Anyway, are you feeling better now?"
Miho Orikasa
"Yep, yep! I was already feeling great by lunchtime yesterday. I basically skipped half the day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What the heeck?"

Meanwhile, I had my spirit completely wrecked yesterday.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, I'm glad you're feeling better."
Miho Orikasa
"Be careful with summer colds, too, Nozomi. I've heard they can be pretty tough to shake."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Funny, coming from the girl who recovered in half a day."

I walked into the classroom, chatting with Miho.
As usual, I was greeted by a barrage of "Good mornings."
I returned each greeting before taking my seat.
...Huh. Kuraguchi-kun isn't here. Maybe he hasn't arrived yet.

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi? Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... no?"
Miho Orikasa
"Come to think of it, the transfer student isn't here today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... yeah, I guess not. Maybe he hasn't arrived yet?"
Miho Orikasa
"Maybe, maybe. I thought he'd already started skipping school."

...Wow. Brutal.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Say, Miho..."
Miho Orikasa
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What do you think of Kuraguchi-kun?"

Miho Orikasa
"Huh? The transfer student? What do I think of him? In what way?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-nothing specific... Just say whatever comes to mind."
Miho Orikasa
"Hmm... well, personally..."

Miho's expression turned serious, and she lowered her voice. I involuntarily held my breath.

Miho Orikasa
"Let's see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's see...?"
Miho Orikasa
"I think he'd be a hottie if he cut his hair."

...Excuse me?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...A hottie?"
Miho Orikasa
"Yup. I don't know, I just have a feeling."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see... Heh... hehe, ahahahaha!"

I relaxed, and before I knew it, I was laughing out loud.

Miho Orikasa
"Uh... what? What's with you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I just... I really like you, Miho."
Miho Orikasa
"Thanks, I guess."

I still don't have the courage to completely open up to Miho, but I feel pretty lucky to have such a good friend.

In the end, Kuraguchi-kun didn't come to class even after the bell rang.
According to the teacher's announcement during homeroom, he was absent because he wasn't feeling well.
A few people snickered again when they heard that.
Part of me couldn't help thinking that maybe it was a good thing Kuraguchi-kun wasn't at school.

Teacher
"Goodbye."
Students
"Goodbye."

The final homeroom of the day came to an end.
Unlike yesterday, the day had passed by peacefully.
This classroom feels so much more peaceful without Kuraguchi-kun. I don't get a stomachache every time break comes around, and I don't have to worry about what we're going to cover in class.
Maybe this really is where I'm happiest. But it doesn't feel as vibrant as it did back in my first year of middle school.

Female student
"Nozomi, you've got a student council meeting today, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yeah. Sorry I haven't been able to help you with your studying lately."
Male student
"Aww, Anesaki-san, so you're busy today?"

A male student sat down next to me. It was Kuraguchi-kun's seat.

Male student
"I was hoping you could help me with math."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry. I think I'll have some time next week."
Male student
"I see. Hmm..."

The boy suddenly glanced down into the desk.

Male student
"Come to think of it, this is Kuraguchi's desk, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah, that's right."
Male student
"There's something in here."

The boy pulled something out from inside the desk. For a moment, my heart skipped a beat.

Female student
"Huh? What's that, a paperback?"
Male student
"Looks like it. I wonder what that guy's always reading."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I felt a cold sweat breaking out.
This is bad... This is really bad... I'm staring down a massive death flag here...
Because if there's one kind of paperback Kuraguchi-kun would be carrying, it's gotta be...
One of those, right...?

Oh nooo... This is bad. There's no way the people in this class would understand that kind of hobby. Absolutely no way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah!!!"

Before I knew what I was doing, I had shouted out loud. Everyone around me jumped.

Female student
"Whoa, what's wrong?!"
Male student
"What happened?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... um... you know... right? Right?"
Female student
"? Hm? What?"
Male student
"Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"....N-nothing. It's nothing…"

Idiot... I'm so, so stupid... There must've been a more convincing way to play that off...!

Female student
"So, what book is that?"
Male student
"Hmm..."

The boy pulled the cover off the paperback.
...Ah, it's over... It's all over... Goodbye, Kuraguchi-kun's peaceful school life...

Male student
"Oh, it's Natsume Sōseki."

....Huh?
I shifted my gaze over, dumbfounded. The title "Kokoro" was written across the cover.

Female student
"Meh... that's so ordinary."
Male student
"It really is. Boring."

He casually tossed back into the desk.
Heeey... So you're going to make fun of him regardless of what he reads? That's seriously unfair...
But at least things turned out okay. If it had been a light novel, they'd probably be having a field day making fun of him right now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to the student council room..."

I was suddenly feeling completely worn out, so I quickly left the classroom.

Mizuho Hoshina
"...All right, I think that's enough for today. Good job, everyone."
Treasurer
"Good work."
Secretary
"Good work, good work."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Anesaki-san? Hellooo?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! Ah, yes! What is it?!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"We're calling it a day, so you can stop there too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... Right. I didn't realize. Good work today..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Is something bothering you? You've seemed kind of out of it this whole time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no... It's nothing. I'm sorry."

Crap... I was so busy thinking about Kuraguchi-kun that I could barely concentrate on my work.
And I didn't even get to properly enjoy my Hoshina-senpai viewing session. ...Such a waste.

Treasurer・Secretary
"President Hoshina, Vice President Anesaki, let's head home!"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Sure. Anesaki-san, shall we go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

The four of us ambled toward the entrance.
We've gotten into the habit of all going home together after our student council meetings.
This is pretty much the only chance I get to walk home with Hoshina-senpai, so this time is really precious to me.
It really is. It's incredibly precious.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, I have somewhere I need to be, so I'll take my leave here."

I told my seniors as we reached the entrance.

Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, I see. Well then, see you next week."
Secretary
"Bye-bye."
Treasurer
"Have a great weekend."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Goodbye."

After seeing them off, I went back the way I'd come.
I stopped in front of my classroom and peeked inside.
...Good. Looks like no one's here.
I hurried into the classroom and reached into the desk next to mine.
I pulled out the book Kuraguchi-kun had left behind and put the cover back on properly.
The weekend starts tomorrow. He probably forgot to take this home.
He might need it right now, so I should probably bring it to him... right?
That's what I told myself as I tucked the book into my bag.
I think, deep down, I was probably just looking for an excuse to go check up on Kuraguchi-kun.

Chapter 7: Visit

I got the teacher to give me a map to Kuraguchi-kun's house, and somehow, through sheer impulse and momentum, I ended up here.
Okay, great. Except...
Now that I'm actually standing here, I'm freaking out. I'm such a coward.
I told him to stay away from me, and now I'm the one coming all the way to his house. If I were Kuraguchi-kun, I'd probably think this was ridiculously selfish.
I just want to see how Kuraguchi-kun is doing. That's all.
If he's really sick, then fine.
But if he stayed home for some other reason...
...Then what? What am I even going to do?
Probably offer him some empty words of encouragement while keeping myself safely removed from the situation.
...Ugh. This is terrible. I'm trash.
A chill suddenly went through me, and I took a step back.
Yeah. Maybe I shouldn't talk to him. I'll just put the book in the mailbox and get out of here.
That's definitely for the best.
Suddenly, the door to Kuraguchi-kun's house opened.
A woman stepped outside.
Oh, that's Ayumu-kun's mother. Wow, I haven't seen her in ages.
Wait, no! That's not important right now...! I've been spotted! What am I gonna do?!

Ayumu's mother
"Oh? You..."

Kuraguchi-kun's mother narrowed her eyes and looked at me intently.
Oh no... Is she going to realize that I'm that Nozomi...?

This is bad. If she figures it out, things are going to get complicated...

Ayumu's mother
"Could you be..."

Gulp...

Ayumu's mother
"Ayumu's friend?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? Uh... um... what?"

Well, I guess that's right, but... not exactly.

Ayumu's mother
"Oh my, I had no idea that boy had such a sweet, adorable girl as a friend!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, wait, um...!"
Ayumu's mother
"Come in, come in! Please, make yourself comfortable."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhh, wait, hold on...!"

She kept pushing me forward, and before I knew it, I had stepped inside the entrance.
Right... Ayumu-kun's mother has always been this pushy…

Ayumu's mother
"I'll go call Ayumu, so please come on in and wait."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! No, um, please don't! I'm going home right away, so...!"
Ayumu's mother
"Ayumuuu! Your friend is heeere!"

Waaah... She isn't listening to me at all.

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um... Kuraguchi-kun is sick, isn't he? I don't want to disturb him, so I thought maybe I should just go..."
Ayumu's mother
"Huh? Oh, don't worry about it. He's not really sick. That's just an excuse."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Ayumu's mother
"He does this all the time. He's got a bad case of 'I-wanna-skip-school-itis.' That boy's depressed, you know. Depressed. Just kidding!"

"Ohohoho," Kuraguchi-kun's mother laughed. Uh... I really don't know how I'm supposed to respond to that... haha.

Nozomi Anesaki
"A-anyway, I really should be going..."
Ayumu's mother
"Oh, there he is! Ayumuuuu! Hurry up and come downstairs!"

I heard the sluggish sound of footsteps coming down the stairs.
Before I could make my escape, Kuraguchi-kun appeared in the entryway.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What is it, Mom...? You're being so noi—"

Kuraguchi-kun froze. His eyes were opened as wide as they could possibly be.
Unsure of what expression to put on, I reflexively lowered my gaze to the floor.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... Nozomi.... Anesaki-san... Why...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...U-uh... I..."

Why? Why is this happening? What did I even come here for again?
Oh god, my mind's gone completely blank.

Ayumu's mother
"Oh my, oh my, let's not just stand here chatting. Come on in. Uh, Anesaki-san, was it? That's right, come in."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh...? No, um..."
Ayumu's mother
"Ayumu, show her to your room, okay? Be a gentleman and escort her properly. Ohoho."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Wait... um... huh? My room...?"
Ayumu's mother
"Ah, your room is a bit of a mess, isn't it? But what can you do? The living room is even more of a disaster."
Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um, I really should be going...!"
Ayumu's mother
"Nonsense! Oh, Anesaki-san, do you like pudding? I bought a whole bunch today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... yes, I do."
Ayumu's mother
"Oh, excellent! I'll bring some to you later. Just wait here for a moment, dear."

And so here I am.
In Kuraguchi-kun's room.

Nozomi Anesaki

"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Naturally, there was no conversation.
The room was drowning in silence as Kuraguchi-kun and I sat facing each other in seiza*. Is this some kind of spiritual trial?
*A formal Japanese sitting posture.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Uh..."

Kuraguchi-kun suddenly spoke up. I instinctively straightened my back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?! What is it?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well... um, sorry about the mess..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, no! No, it's fine!"

It was true that Kuraguchi-kun's room was hardly what you'd call clean.
Notebooks and sheets of manuscript paper were scattered all over the place.
They looked like they had something written on them, but I felt a little guilty about poking around and staring, so I just looked somewhere else.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So... um... what brings you here today...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yes. Um, well, today..."

For some reason, he opened the conversation in a rather businesslike way, but at least we'd finally started talking.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I came to give you this."

I pulled a paperback from my bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kuraguchi-kun, you left this behind. I figured you might need it, especially with the weekend coming up..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, ohh... Thank goodness... I'd been looking for this. Thanks for bringing it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's no trouble at all..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Silence. Oh no... I have to say something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-you're really studious!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...We're doing 'Kokoro' in class right now, aren't we? So I figured that's why you were reading it."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
" 'Kokoro'...? Hm...? Oh! Ah, you mean this book."

Kuraguchi-kun reacted strangely.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"This isn't 'Kokoro.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I changed the cover."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, you did?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. When I dropped the book after bumping into you the other day, the cover came loose, remember?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I figured just replacing the outer cover wouldn't be enough, so I decided to change the cover underneath it, too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-ohh..."

Impressive, Kuraguchi-kun. That was the right call…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"The book inside is actually one I borrowed from the library the other day. It's from the 'Grade X' series."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, I see."

Whew... That could've been bad. I'm glad nobody in class actually read through it.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

And then, once again, silence.
I'd already done what I came here for, and Kuraguchi-kun was doing better than I'd expected. There wasn't really any reason for me to stick around anymore... except the pudding still hadn't arrived.
I wish Kuraguchi-kun's mother would hurry up and bring it... I don't know what to say to fill the silence...
.....
Ah.
...Come to think of it, there was something I'd meant to tell him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"By then, I was..."

I still haven't thanked him for what happened yesterday.
We've finally gotten into a more serious mood, so this is probably the time to say it. I'll feel better if I just get it out of the way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um, Kuraguchi-kun."
Ayumu's mother
"Comiiiing!"

Kuraguchi-kun's mother silently appeared out of nowhere.

Ayumu's mother
"Sorry to keep you waiting! Pudding's here!"
Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."
Ayumu's mother
"Oh my, what's with those serious faces, you two?"
Ayumu's mother
"Ah! Wait, am I interrupting something? I totally killed the vibe, huh? Totes awkward? Oho, ohohoho."

At this point, I couldn't even force a laugh...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mom... that's enough. Just leave the pudding there and go."
Ayumu's mother
"Yes, yes. ...Wait, oh my!"

She set the pudding on the floor and dramatically blinked a few times.

Ayumu's mother
"What a filthy room!!!"

You're only noticing that now?

Ayumu's mother
"Oh, honestly, Ayumu. At least clean up around Anesaki-san, won't you?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Okay, okay."
Ayumu's mother
"And what's all this manuscript paper? Are you writing something weird again?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Yes, yes. Please go."
Ayumu's mother
"Not so faaast. If you're going to write, you should aim to be the next Natsume Sōseki!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Okay, okay, I said I got it."

Kuraguchi-kun pushed his mother out of the room and shut the door behind her with a loud thud.
The room fell completely silent.
Not knowing what to say, I kept silent as Kuraguchi-kun started cleaning up the manuscript pages and notebooks scattered across the floor.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Sorry. I'll tidy up a little more."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... no, really, you don't have to. Don't mind me..."

But Kuraguchi-kun kept diligently cleaning up, so I absentmindedly reached for the manuscript pages scattered nearby.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? Anesaki-san, you can just sit and relax."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'll help. I feel kind of awkward just sitting here."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Okay."

The two of us began quietly cleaning up the room.
There really were an awful lot of manuscript pages.
I wonder what's written on them...
His mother's earlier remark had piqued my curiosity, and before I knew it, I was reading the pages.
.....
...Oh. I see.

Teacher
"...All right, next up is Kimura-san. Tell us a little about Kuraguchi-kun."
Nozomi Kimura
"Yes."
Nozomi Kimura

"Ayumu Kuraguchi-kun likes reading, and he wants to become a writer someday."

So that's what it is.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun... you still want to become a writer..."

.....
.....
Ah. Did I say that out loud?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun stopped what he was doing and stared intently at me. ...It seemed he had heard me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ahem."

I cleared my throat lightly and quickly returned to cleaning.
I soon noticed that Kuraguchi-kun had started working again as well.
After that, neither of us said another word. We simply gathered up the manuscript pages in silence, focusing only on the task at hand.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thanks for the treat..."

I finished my pudding sitting in the middle of the now spotless room.
Even while I was eating, there was hardly any conversation between Kuraguchi-kun and me.
It's getting a little uncomfortable. I should probably head home.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I should probably get going."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, yeah. Um... thanks for today. And for going out of your way to bring me the book."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't mention it... Well, see you..."

I picked up my bag and stood up.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I've gotten better at reading the room than I used to be."
Nozomi Anesaki

"...Huh...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Where I stand. How other people see me... I understand those things, at least to some degree."

"...I think, anyway," he added uncertainly.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"And I also understand... that you're not the same person you were back then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"That's why..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I won't cause you any trouble. You don't have to worry."

He smiled gently at me.
I couldn't think of a single thing to say. I silently left Kuraguchi-kun's room.

Ayumu's mother
"Oh? Anesaki-san, are you leaving already?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yes. Thank you for having me."
Ayumu's mother
"It's getting dark... Ayumu, you should walk her home."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No!!! Really, you don't have to!!! I live close by!!! I can get home just fine!!!"
Ayumu's mother
"Oh, really? You sure you'll be all right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes! I'll be totally fine!"
Ayumu's mother
"Ayumu, you're so lucky."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"? Lucky?"
Ayumu's mother
"To have such a sensible girl become your friend."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

His mother cheerfully carried on talking, while we just stood there, not knowing what to say.

Ayumu's mother
"Anesaki-san, you know, this kid doesn't have any friends at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

Ayumu's mother
"That's why he's always skipping school at every opportunity. He's such a naughty boy, isn't he?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mom... please, just stop."
Ayumu's mother
"He used to love going to school... but then Nozomi-chan transferred away..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mom."

Kuraguchi-kun raised his voice, and his mother responded with an exaggerated sigh.

Ayumu's mother
"Sorry, I got a little carried away."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, it's fine..."
Ayumu's mother
"But really, please take good care of my son."

Kuraguchi-kun's mother bowed politely. Once again, I found myself at a loss for words.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mom, you don't need to say all that. And Anesaki-san, don't worry about any of it, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well then, see you later, Anesaki-san. Take care."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah... See you."

.....
I was feeling strangely conflicted.
I didn't even know anymore what kind of relationship I wanted with Kuraguchi-kun.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I won't cause you any trouble. You don't have to worry."

I couldn't get Kuraguchi-kun's words out of my head.
That was exactly what I'd said to Shun only a few days ago.
Could it be that Kuraguchi-kun feels the same way about me as I do about Shun?
...That's strange. It's not like I'm some admirable person.
The fact that Ayumu-kun feels inferior to me... somehow, it just...
Feels awful.

Chapter 8: The following week

When I got to school the next week, Kuraguchi-kun wasn't there. Apparently, he'd stayed home sick again.

Miho Orikasa
"Summer colds can be so stubborn."

That's what Miho said, but I knew there was some other reason for Kuraguchi-kun's absence.
We had English Practice and P.E. that day, and everyone found a partner in both classes without any trouble.

Male student
"Kuraguchi, you're lucky you missed school."

I overheard the boys talking about it, laughing amongst themselves.
Part of me thought they were right, but at the same time, I was unable to settle the restless feeling inside me.
The next day.
Kuraguchi-kun came to school.
My relief was short-lived. He passed by me without a word and quietly took his seat.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

We didn't greet each other. We didn't even look at one another.
To an outside observer, there might not have been anything particularly unusual about it.
But after everything that had happened, I couldn't help finding the distance between Kuraguchi-kun and me unsettling.
The morning homeroom was over, and we had a short break before the next class.
I stole a glance at Kuraguchi-kun. He was busy rummaging through his things and getting ready for class.
Maybe... I should try talking to him. Just a little... Even if it's only to say hello...
Once I'd made up my mind, I gathered my courage and turned fully toward him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Kura—"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun stood up from his seat with his notebook and stationery in hand.
He walked straight out of the classroom before I even had a chance to say anything.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Uh...
HUUUH...?

Male student
"Anesaki-san. There's something I wanna ask you."

Female student
"Nozomi! Pay attention to meeee!"

Before I knew it, a crowd had gathered around my desk.
I smiled and answered them as best I could, but internally, I was ready to tear my hair out.
That day, Kuraguchi-kun disappeared from the classroom during every break.
When lunchtime came, I realized his seat was empty again.
We had no interaction in class, either. Though our seats were side by side, we existed entirely apart from each other.
In the end, I didn't even get to have a single mundane exchange with Kuraguchi-kun.
Not once. For the entire week.

Chapter 9: Out with my 2-min getup

Saturday.
At long last, the weekend was here.
This week had felt incredibly long, and I was mentally exhausted.
I slept until well past noon, then dragged myself lazily toward the bathroom.
I washed my face and peered into the mirror... Oh no, my skin looks so dull.
Pat, pat, pat...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We've got a problem."
Shun Anesaki
"What's wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We ran out of face masks."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Go buy some more."
Shun Anesaki
"No way. Go get them yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on. You don't have anything to do today anyway, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Neither do you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Just go get them."
Shun Anesaki
"I said no. Why do I have to go out and buy your stuff for you?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I don't feel like getting changed."
Shun Anesaki
"It's no big deal. Just throw something on and go grab some."

...Grr. As if he doesn't know how long it takes me to get ready.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Meanie."
Shun Anesaki
"...Listen. I'm just gonna say it straight: you always take way too long getting ready, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"There is nothing I can do about it. Believe it or not, this is actually my fast."
Shun Anesaki
"No... It's because you waste all that time on the most pointless stuff. You spend 10, 20 minutes on things that don't make a lick of difference to anyone else."
Shun Anesaki
"For starters, you don't need those face masks. Do they actually work? Isn't it just a placebo?"
Shun Anesaki
"Actually, I'm pretty sure they're just doing the opposite and putting more strain on your skin. You should seriously stop."
Shun Anesaki
"And while I'm at it—spending ages blow-drying your hair? Placebo. Eyelash curling? Placebo. Facial massages and beauty exercises? All placebo."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Grrr!
My brother writes off all my hard work as "placebo." This guy wants to become a hairstylist, for crying out loud. Is he seriously saying this stuff?
.....
...Heh.
You know what? If that's how he feels, I'll just have to show him.
I'll make him see just how effective those "placebos" of his can be...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll go get changed."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm? Oh, so you've finally decided to go yourself?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmph."

I went back to my room and changed into whatever was lying around.
A T-shirt and jeans. I also just tied my hair back quickly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"There. Done."

After spending about two minutes getting ready, I returned to the living room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"How's this?"

I stood proudly in front of Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Look! This is what zero effort looks like!"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm? Okay."

Shun glanced at me for just a split second before turning his gaze back to the TV.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait! Don't you have anything else to say?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Yeah. Looks fine to me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! No, actually look at me! Look at what I'm wearing. See? This T-shirt cost 500 yen. I got it at Shi○mura!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh. That's cheap."
Nozomi Anesaki
"My hair's all dry and frizzy, the ends are sticking out, my skin has no firmness or glow, and my eyes look smaller than usual, don't they?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm..."

Shun stared intently at my face.

Shun Anesaki
"Nope. Can't tell the difference."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

What... did you just say...?
My carefully put-together look that normally takes me over an hour, and this two-minute getup... they look exactly the same...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"THAT CAN'T BEEEE!!!"

I grabbed Shun by the front of his shirt.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're seriously okay with me going out like this?!"

Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Yeah. It's fine. Now move. You're blocking the TV."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait... I'm really going out, you know! I mean it!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah. Take care."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't come crying to me when I run into your friends!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Sure, sure. Man, you're so loud."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'M REALLY GOING! See ya!"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah! No, wait! Hold on!"

Shun quickly looked back at me.
...See? I knew he wouldn't actually want that.
Surely he finally understands now. That all those so-called "placebos" Shun keeps dismissing are what make me the beautiful Nozomi Anesaki I usually am—

Shun Anesaki
"Pick up some chips while you're out. Consommé flavor."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I silently walked out of the house.

Chapter 10: Grade 9

They say there are two types of people: those who can go anywhere bare-faced, and people who can't even leave the house without makeup.
I am, without a doubt, the latter.
I don't even like going to the vending machine one minute away unless I'm all dressed up.
...Which is why I've been incredibly self-conscious this whole time.
Every time I see my sorry-looking reflection in a shop window, I shudder. I really should have dressed properly.
Anyway, mission accomplished: face masks and potato chips acquired.
Ugh, I hate how packed everywhere is on weekends. I need to get home before I run into somebody.
I started running, keeping my head slightly down...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ow...!"

I bumped into something.
I raised my head and...
Whoa. Three impeccably styled young men were looking down at me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I... I'm so sorry..."

I bowed repeatedly and hurried past them.

Man
"Hold on."

He grabbed me by the arm.

Nozomi Anesaki
"?! W-wait, what are you—!"

Before I could do anything, I was dragged behind a shop where hardly anyone was around.

Man
"Are you alone?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, um... well... M-my mom, dad, little brother, grandparents and cousins are somewhere awound here...!"

I was so flustered I actually fumbled my words. The men snickered.

Man
"Looks like she's alone."
Man
"Actually... she's kinda cute when you look at her."
Man
"Yeah. Not bad."
Men
"Too bad she dresses like that."

...I really shouldn't have gone out in my two-minute getup. I just want to get home and hide in my room.
...Hold on. This is... actually pretty dangerous, isn't it...?
Could this be one of those "delinquent encounter events" you see all the time in otome games...?
Huh? Wait... what? S-seriously?! Wh-what am I supposed to do?!
It took me a moment to realize just how serious things had gotten.
The man in front of me reached a hand toward my shoulder.

Man
"Got some time? You do, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no! No, I don't!"
Man
"Where do you wanna go?"
Man

"How about karaoke?"
Men
"Or maybe a hotel?"

Eeeek!!!
I instinctively swatted the man's hand away.
He stumbled slightly, then closed in on me, looking enraged.

Man
"Come on, let's go to a hotel."

His arm roughly wrapped around my shoulders again.
This is bad. What am I supposed to do? This is getting seriously dangerous...!
In an otome game, this would be the moment when one of the love interests comes rushing in to rescue me!
But reality doesn't work that way. I've got to protect myself.
I need to scream, run, and get away...!
I drew in a deep breath...

???
"Stop!!!"

A firm, commanding voice rang out.
Backlit by the sun, the silhouette of a tall man appeared.
Th-that... could it be...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Lo... Lord Wald...?"

As if. Obviously not.
...But still... thank goodness... I never thought Kuraguchi-kun would show up at a moment like this...
I'd actually started to think maybe we wouldn't have anything to do with each other ever again...
Relieved in every sense of the word, I suddenly felt all the strength drain out of me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Let her go."

Kuraguchi-kun's voice was unusually resolute and dignified. His eyes, usually hidden by his bangs, were sharp and piercing.
I forgot all about running away. I could only stand there, mesmerized by the sight of him.

Man
"Huuuh? Who the hell are you?"
Man
"Her boyfriend?"
Man

"Looks like a scrawny little runt."

The men shoved me aside and surrounded Kuraguchi-kun instead.
All three of them conspicuously clenched their fists.

Man
"Oi."

One of the men grabbed Kuraguchi-kun by the front of his shirt.
And then...
A streak of blinding light flashed before my eyes.
Flames of blue-white fire suddenly erupted from his right arm.

Man
"Wh-whoa?! What is this?!"
Man
"It's hot!!! Wh-what's going on?!"
Man
"Shit! Something's seriously wrong with this guy!!!"
Men
"Run!!!"

The men took off at full speed.
Completely dumbfounded, I could only stare up at Kuraguchi-kun, flames swirling around him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ku-Kuraguchi-kun... just who are you...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun smiled slowly. Bathed in the blue-white glow, his smile looked almost ethereal.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Anesaki-san... I've kept this from you until now, but... I..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm a Grade 9 ability user."

...This reminded me of a light novel I'd read once.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ack...!"

A heavy thud abruptly snapped me back to reality.
When I realized what was happening, Kuraguchi-kun was sprawled on the ground.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Ku-Kuraguchi-kun!!!"

I rushed over to him, but one of the men grabbed my arm and held me in place.

Nozomi Anesaki
"H-hey! Let go of me!!!"
Man
"You're only getting in the way, so be a good girl and stay still."

The more I struggled, the tighter his grip became.
I can't move. I have to scream for help!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hel—!"

A hand clamped over my mouth.

Man
"Now, be quiet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mmph!"

This is bad, my voice is completely muffled.
With me powerless to stop them, the men kicked Kuraguchi-kun in the face again.
After doing it several times, they suddenly stopped.

Man
"Damn, this guy... he's so weak it's boring."
Man
"I'm starting to feel kinda bad for him. Should we call it quits?"
Man
"Yeah. Let's go through his bag, though. Maybe he's got something good."

The man unzipped Kuraguchi-kun's bag, turned it upside down, and began shaking it roughly.
Its contents tumbled out onto the ground, most of them books.

Man
"What the hell is this... books?"
Man
"Oh, yeah. These are those books otaku read."
Man
"Whoa, seriously? It's that 'moe' crap. Cringe."
Man
"So you're an otaku, huh? Gross."
Man
"Read Sōseki-san's stuff instead, dude."
Man

"It's nothing but books. What a crappy haul."
Man
"Let's just get outta here."

The men got to their feet, visibly unimpressed, and left, kicking the books out of their way.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ku-Kuraguchi-kun... Are you okay...?"

I gently shook Kuraguchi-kun, who was still lying face-down on the ground.
After coughing several times, he slowly pushed himself upright.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mm... Yeah... I'm okay..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"B-but you're really hurt..."

Blood was trickling from his nose. His cheek was swollen, and bruises were already forming.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well... it hurts a little, but it's not as bad as it looks."

Kuraguchi-kun wiped the blood from his nose with his sleeve and gave me a weak smile.
Just looking at him made me wince.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let me take care of your injuries."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"My house is right nearby. If you go home like this, your mom's going to freak out. At least let me give you some first aid."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"But... still..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Pretty please?"

I wanted to take the opportunity to have a nice, leisurely conversation with Kuraguchi-kun.
I can never seem to talk to him properly at school, so I thought maybe today could be different.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun looked away uneasily, then silently nodded.

Chapter 11: Reunion

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm back."
Shun Anesaki
"Welcome. Did you get the chips I asked? Consommé flavor."

...My brother sure is carefree.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I got them. But first, get the antiseptic."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Antiseptic? What for—whoa! What happened to that guy?"

When Shun noticed Kuraguchi-kun, his eyes widened in surprise.
I quickly kicked off my shoes and helped Kuraguchi-kun inside, supporting him as we went.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Um, excuse me for intruding..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on in."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh? Who is this? What is happening?"

I slipped past the confused Shun and headed for my room.
Now that I think about it, it's been ages since I had anyone other than Shun in my room.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Is this your room, Anesaki-san?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, that's right."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ohh... It's nice."

Kuraguchi-kun muttered, sounding impressed.
Well, of course. I keep my room neat and tidy every day, just in case someone happens to drop by.
I also make sure there aren't any obvious signs of my otaku interests lying around. The inside of my closet and desk, on the other hand, is an entirely different story. It's chaos in there.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey, I got the antiseptic..."

Shun hesitantly entered the room.
He kept stealing quick looks at Kuraguchi-kun before suddenly going, "Oh!" as if he'd just realized something.

Shun Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh... I see. Hmm... Well, make yourself at home."

Shun practically fled the room. He's not going to help me patch him up?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Who was that just now...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahh, that's my younger brother. His name is Shun. He's a year younger than me."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? I didn't know you had a younger brother, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, he's my stepbrother. My dad remarried when I transferred schools."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh... I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."

The conversation trailed off.
Suddenly feeling a little restless, I quickly started getting the first-aid supplies ready.
Ah... shoot, I'm running low on cotton. I should've picked some up while I was out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Does it hurt?"

I sat down in front of Kuraguchi-kun, soaking a cotton pad with antiseptic.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm... Well... I've gotten pretty used to it by now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Has your nosebleed stopped completely?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, I think so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let me take a look."

I gently brushed Kuraguchi-kun's bangs back.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

Somehow, our eyes met.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"!"

Kuraguchi-kun seemed to realize he was staring, his eyes nervously darting from side to side. His reaction made me instinctively look down, too.
Why is this so embarrassing...? It's like I'm living through an otome-game scene right now.
...Wait, now that I think about it... I'm in my zero-effort 2-minute getup...!
Aahhh, this is awful. I can't believe someone saw me looking like this...
But...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Kuraguchi-kun was just staring blankly at the wall.
Well... whatever. I mean, it's just Kuraguchi-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...By the way... I'm sorry I dragged you into all this..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh? No, I'm the one who should be apologizing. I didn't really do much to help..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! Don't say that! If you hadn't shown up, I don't know what would've happened to me...!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hahaha... Thanks. I appreciate that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, really. You saved me. Thank you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-you're welcome..."

I gently dabbed Kuraguchi-kun's cheek with the cotton pad.
Our eyes met again.

Ayumu・Nozomi
"..."

We both quickly looked away in opposite directions.

Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way, those guys were beyond awful!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah! They really were. I didn't think people like that actually existed outside of fiction."
Nozomi Anesaki
"They were like textbook bad guys."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I thought I could settle things just by talking to them... I was too naive. I really am pathetic..."

Seeing Kuraguchi-kun hunch his shoulders in embarrassment, I hurriedly shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No! Y-you were really cool! For a second, you looked just like Lo—"

I nearly blurted out "Lord Wald," but quickly clammed up.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Lo...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-it's nothing! Forget it..."

That was a close call.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Things don't go as smoothly in real life as they do in novels..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...If I were a Grade 9 ability user, things wouldn't have turned out like this."

Kuraguchi-kun mused quietly. My hands stopped mid-motion, and I stared intently at his face.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ah."

A moment later, Kuraguchi-kun seemed to realize what he'd just said, and his expression turned awkward.
"Grade 9 ability user"...?
What the heck is that supposed to mean? Is he a chūnibyō* or something? What a weirdo.
*Teenagers who get carried away imagining they have hidden knowledge or secret powers.
The absurdity of it suddenly got to me, and I burst out laughing.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Pfft! Hehe... Ahahaha!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahahaha! This is hilarious! You were thinking the same thing I was!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? The same thing? What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The 'Grade X' series... They had a scene exactly like that!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... y-yeah. Wait, what...?"

I can't believe how well we still click. I guess we really haven't changed at all since back then.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually..."

Once I'd finished treating Kuraguchi-kun's injuries, I put the first-aid kit away in the closet. Then, in its place, I pulled out a box several times larger.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I said I'd changed... but that was a lie."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"

Kuraguchi-kun tilted his head in confusion as I opened the box in front of him.
Manga. Light novels. Anime DVDs. Games... It was crammed full of all the things I loved most.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... is this... yours...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. It's all mine. I still love this stuff."

Actually, I've been really into otome games lately... but I'll save that for another time.

Nozomi Anesaki
"The truth is, Kuraguchi-kun... I'm still exactly the same."

Just like a light novel disguised with a cover of "Kokoro."
Even if I put on the appearance of "the brilliant, beautiful vice president," underneath it all, I'm still just the same otaku I was back in middle school.
That's why...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I was so happy to see you again, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I'm glad."

Chapter 12: Just as we were

After that, we talked for what felt like ages about all sorts of things.
The manga and anime we'd been into lately, the light novels Ayumu-kun recommended, and plenty more.
We also talked about "Grade X."
The series had made it to ten volumes when we were in middle school, but apparently, it was still going strong.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I went out to buy the latest volume today. ...Though they pretty much trashed it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... They were kicking it and everything. What jerks."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well, at least it was my own copy. It would've been a problem if it was from school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Oh, that reminds me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, didn't you borrow 'Grade X' from the school library?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm? Yeah. That was the book you brought over the other day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But you already have the series. Why borrow them?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... I somehow lost one of the volumes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? You lost one?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. I couldn't find it anywhere. I checked the school library just in case, and they had a copy. I felt like reading it again, so I borrowed it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"The library's pretty impressive, isn't it? They've got books from all sorts of genres."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really? I don't go there very often, so I didn't know."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I go there a lot. I'm in the library pretty much every break."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."

Come to think of it, Ayumu-kun had been disappearing from the classroom every break this past week.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I'm sorry about all this..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"During break... I'm kind of in your way, aren't I?"

With several people gathered around my desk, they hardly leave Ayumu-kun any space.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, not at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really...? But..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, I don't go to the library because of that. I just go because I want to."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is that true?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. I like it there. There's no one around, and I can concentrate."
Nozomi Anesaki
"On reading?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm... Well... I do read there..."

Ayumu-kun hesitated. He seemed to struggle to find the right words for a while, then finally made up his mind and spoke.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...It's just like you said, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm still trying to become a writer."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...A light novel writer, that is."

He added, sounding a little embarrassed.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So... I was thinking about entering the Shogeki Bunko Newcomer Award this year. I'm working on a story for it right now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-ohh..."

So that's what it was. That explains all those notebooks and sheets of manuscript paper scattered around Ayumu-kun's room.
...Wait, could it be?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Were you writing during class, too?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What...? Ah... you saw it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. During modern Japanese class the other day, I noticed you were really focused on writing something."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... y-yeah... well, that's right."

A slight blush spread across Ayumu-kun's cheeks. He looked embarrassed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh... hmm... mm..."

I see. So Ayumu-kun is still pursuing his dream of becoming a writer.

Nozomi Kimura
"Huh? Ayumu-kun, you're writing your own novel?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-yeah... sort of..."
Nozomi Kimura
"I wanna read it! Let me read it, let me read it!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh..."
Nozomi Kimura
"Please!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hmm... Fine... Just a little..."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...W-well...?"
Nozomi Kimura
"...This..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...This...?"
Nozomi Kimura
"THIS IS SO GOOD!!! Oh my gosh, it's just amazing!!! What happens next?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?! No, I-I haven't written it yet."
Nozomi Kimura
"Aww, but I'm so curious! I wanna read more! Let me read it when you're done!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... S-sure..."

Ah... how nostalgic. After that day, Ayumu-kun would often let me read what he wrote.
Then I transferred away, and I never got to find out how the story ended. But Ayumu-kun had continued writing all this time.
I couldn't help but think that...

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's lovely."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Lovely?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... I mean, I love that you're still writing novels."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I wanna finish that story you wrote. How did it end?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...What? Um... well... actually... I never finished it. I lost the notebook I was writing it in..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really? That's such a shame... It was so good."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... hahaha... You think so? If I read it now, I'd probably want to die of embarrassment..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahahaha. Then let me read what you're working on now. I really like the stories you write, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

He was silently staring at me, and after a while, I met his eyes.
Staare...

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

This time, I looked away first. Yet I could still feel his gaze fixed on me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...You really... haven't changed at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You've always looked at my writing without prejudice."

Nozomi Kimura
"I see... So you want to become a writer."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah... Ah, no! I mean, it's not like I'm trying to be some literary master like Natsume Sōseki!"
Nozomi Kimura
"? A writer is a writer, no?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"

Nozomi Kimura
"Are his novels really so different from yours?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... yeah... y-yeah...? I think... They're different... I guess?"
Nozomi Kimura
"Hmm? But I think it's irrelevant."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What...?"
Nozomi Kimura
"What matters is that they're yours."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's true that what I write isn't anything like a Natsume Sōseki novel. But there are things I want to tell and express in my own way."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"People have started seeing some forms of culture as more worthwhile than others, so my writing often gets dismissed before anyone even gives it a chance."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"But you, Nozomi-chan, never let yourself be bound by other people's standards. You judged my novels purely on their own merits."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
" 'What matters is that they're yours.' "
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"This really meant a lot to me. Thank you."

The uncertainty that had clouded Ayumu-kun's expression moments ago vanished, replaced by a radiant smile.
The same beautiful, intent gaze he'd had while absorbed in his writing now pierced straight through me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan... I never had the confidence to say this outright before, but... I..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm going to become a light novel author."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah! Y-yeah...!"

My heart skipped a beat. …Well played, Ayumu-kun...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well... sorry for staying so long. Thank you for taking care of me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I should be thanking you. I had a lot of fun talking with you today."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, me too. Well then..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait! Ayumu-kun!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you... coming to school on Monday…?"

Ayumu-kun had missed two days of school over the past week.
Both were officially chalked up to "poor health," but I knew that wasn't the real reason.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you... hate coming to school?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I get it. You don't feel comfortable in our class, do you? Neither do I..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, no... I mean, yeah, that's part of it, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"If I showed up at school... I think... it'd make things difficult for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."

I think I understood what Ayumu-kun was getting at. But still...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't mind. It's not like I hate being paired up with you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No... I think it'd be better if you kept your distance from me as much as possible."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Because if you're seen with me, people will start looking at you strangely too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I hate that part of me thinks he might be right.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"And besides... I find it a little difficult to be around you, too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Because the person you've become... you're just too dazzling to me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

...What is that supposed to mean...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Haha."

"Too dazzling"...? Me?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun. I'm still... the same person I was in middle school, you know?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...That's… true, I guess..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"At school, I just put on an act. I pretend to be this model student, but half the time I'm thinking the exact opposite of what I say."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's the same with my appearance. I just spend hours every day making myself look this way. Everyone else falls for it, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Look closer."

I stepped right in front of him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I look kinda lame today, right? Oh, and this? It's a 500-yen T-shirt."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...W-well, don't look at me like that..."

My cheeks grew hot, and I stumbled backward.
That's when I heard a faint sound behind me.

???
"Hey, hey, what's with all the lovey-dovey stuff...? What is this, some otome game?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun!"

I spun around. A loud clatter came from beside the living room door.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you hiding for? Come out."
Shun Anesaki
"N-no... it's not like I was hiding or anything..."

Shun emerged from the living room, fumbling for an excuse.

Shun Anesaki
"It's just that you two were getting all lovey-dovey, so I couldn't exactly come out."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what are you saying?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah. ...So, is he leaving?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... yeah. Thanks for having me."

Ayumu-kun bowed his head slightly and started to leave. I called out to his departing figure again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Come to school on Monday, okay?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Hmm..."

Ayumu-kun stopped and fell silent for a moment, seemingly thinking it over.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I wish I could… become a little more attractive, too..."

He murmured bashfully, his voice so quiet I had to strain my ears to hear him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, well...! I know it's impossible, but... still..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I was thinking that if I could become just a little more handsome... maybe I'd be able to talk to you at school..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I just don't feel confident enough as I am now. You might be okay with it, but... I'm not."

...Yeah. Ayumu-kun really is the same as me.
I think he's fine just the way he is.
And yet, I understood all too well that he couldn't simply change how he felt.
Which is why...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

When I called his name, the expression on Shun's face tightened.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's your time to shine."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Sure, I guess."

Chapter 13: Cinderella Boy

I spread newspapers across the floor of the six-and-a-half-tatami* room.
*approx. 9.72-10.92 m² depending on regional standard.
Ayumu-kun sat seiza-style in the middle, wearing a haircut cape and looking slightly nervous.

Shun Anesaki
"How do you want it cut?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Like Lord Wald's."
Shun Anesaki
"Didn't ask you, Sis."

...Tch.

Shun Anesaki
"Um... Ayumu-kun, right...? What do you think?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh...? Oh, anything's fine..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then Lord Wa—"
Shun Anesaki
"Anything... I mean... don't you have a dream look or something?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...U-um... I'm kind of clueless about this stuff..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"As long as you can make it so Nozomi-chan won't have to feel embarrassed when she's with me... anything is fine..."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm... then..."
Shun・Nozomi
"Let's go with Lord Wald."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yaay!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Huh...?"
Shun Anesaki
"You win. Lord Wald it is."

Shun stood behind Ayumu-kun, scissors in hand.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, make sure you do it right! You can't mess this up!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"We're going for Lord Wald, remember? Oh, do you need references? I've got them from every angle!"
Shun Anesaki
"Don't need 'em. And you're kinda loud, so can you get out of the room?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What the heck? That's mean."
Shun Anesaki
"Just go. You're too loud. I can't concentrate."

...You punk...

Shun Anesaki
"And anyway, isn't it more fun to save the reveal for later?"

...Well, he's got a point.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, I'll leave you to it. Call me when you're finished."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"We're going for Lord Wald, don't forget! Lord Wald!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, I heard you. Now leave."

I left Shun's room feeling like I'd practically been kicked out.
Honestly, what's up with that attitude of his?
But still...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hehehe."

This is actually getting kind of exciting.
What is Ayumu-kun going to look like? Is he really going to turn into Lord Wald?
Oh my gosh, what am I going to do? I need to get a grip now so I don't accidentally start rolling around on the floor.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"B-by the way..."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I've been wondering... who exactly is 'Lord Wald'?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah... Lord Wald is..."
Shun Anesaki
"Her imaginary boyfriend?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Eh, don't worry about it. She'll get tired of him eventually anyway."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uhh..."
Shun Anesaki
"Listen..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Take care of my sister."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Sis looked like she was having a great time talking to you."
Shun Anesaki
"I've never seen her like that before. I think you're someone who can stand beside her as an equal."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...So, yeah. Take care of her."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Um... what exactly do you mean by that...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"You know..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-yeah?"
Shun Anesaki
"You should play some otome games."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"

Wald
"Nozomi... It's been a while."
Nozomi
"Lord Wald... I'm so happy to see you...!"
Wald
"I couldn't bring myself to eat while you were away..."
Nozomi
"Huh... What do you mean by that...?"
Wald
"Haha... Nozomi, you really are oblivious."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's sooo trueee."

It's obvious Lord Wald is making a move on her. Why is the heroine so incredibly dense? Wait...

Nozomi Anesaki
"The heroine is me! Kyaa!"

Rustle, rustle.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sis!"

The sound of knocking pulled me back to reality.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, is it done already?"

I turned off the game and stepped out of my room, where I found Shun standing there with a look I couldn't quite read.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did Ayumu-kun become Lord Wald?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uhh..."

The corner of Shun's mouth twitched.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, don't tell me you messed it up?!"
Shun Anesaki
"No! I didn't mess anything up! It's just..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just what?"
Shun Anesaki
"...It's probably a little different from what you were picturing, Sis... haha."
Nozomi Anesaki

"...I see."

Well... I guess... Yeah, mm-hmm.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Makes sense... The 3D world can never compete with 2D."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun isn't even blond or blue-eyed, after all."
Shun Anesaki
"That's not what I'm talking about..."

We chatted as we made our way to Shun's room.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey... Ayumu-kun? I brought Sis. Can we come in?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, yeah... C-come in..."

Ayumu-kun sounded a little tense. That was making me nervous, too.
I wonder what he looks like now...
Shun said he looked different from what I'd imagined... Did he mean that in a good way? Or a bad way?
W-well... better not get my hopes up too high! I'll just set my expectations at Lord Wald after he's taken about twenty punches.

Shun Anesaki
"...Go ahead."

Shun opened the door.
I slowly stepped into the room...

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...So?"

.....
...I... I see...
I see... So that's what he meant...!
Th-this is...
I don't even know what to say...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Your face is so swollen..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Those bruises are really something..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're all beat up..."
Shun Anesaki
"He really is..."

He did pretty much look like Lord Wald after about twenty punches to the face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well, it'll heal soon enough, right?!"

I stood in front of Ayumu-kun and studied his face closely.
Setting the injury issue aside for a moment...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, you look nice and refreshed!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-you think so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mhm, mhm! Nice work, Shun!"
Shun Anesaki
"...I guess."

Shun deftly twirled the scissors between his fingers. It was probably his way of hiding his embarrassment, but that's seriously dangerous.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Do I... look a little better now...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You do! You totally do! Right, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"O-okay… Thanks, Shun-kun."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

The speed at which Shun is spinning the scissors is getting ridiculous. At this rate, he could probably mow the lawn with them.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come to school on Monday, okay?"

I looked Ayumu-kun in the eyes and asked him again. He faltered for just a moment.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Mhm."

But then he nodded firmly, his expression showing no hesitation.

Chapter 14: Fond memories

What a nice evening. It's been a while since I've felt this good.
I've already done my prep for Monday, and I'm completely caught up on all my subjects, too.
I can afford to stay up a little late tonight, so maybe I'll play some games.
...Actually, never mind.
After talking with Ayumu-kun earlier today, I felt like reading a light novel again.
I pulled my otaku storage box out of the closet and removed the lid.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What should I read...?"

"Table Tennis Club"... "Usakame!*"... Hmm... I'm kind of in the mood for something more thrilling.
*lit. rabbiturtle
Something like the "Grade X" series...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, there it is! The 'Grade X' series."

.....

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, why is this even here?!"

I immediately realized what I'd said was absurd.
But sure enough, there was a single "Grade X" book wedged between the other series.
...Something's not right. I don't remember buying this series myself.
I always borrowed the volumes from Ayumu-kun—wait...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I somehow lost one of the volumes."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I couldn't find it anywhere. I checked the school library just in case, and they had a copy. I felt like reading it again, so I borrowed it."

Nozomi Anesaki
"AAAH!!!"

Oh… right. Now I remember…!
I moved away while I still had the 'Grade X' volume I'd borrowed from Ayumu-kun…!
So the book Ayumu-kun thought he'd lost must have been this one.
…Then that means…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I wanna finish that story you wrote. How did it end?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...What? Um... well... actually... I never finished it. I lost the notebook I was writing it in..."

Oh... and also... I'm pretty sure I borrowed that notebook from Ayumu-kun, too…
I searched through the places in my desk drawers where I thought it might be…
...And there it was.
A completely ordinary notebook.

Image:
Novel: A misunderstanding over a ¥10,000 bill involving MC's friend's girlfriend strains their friendship. He thinks he can no longer afford to skip lectures at his ordinary university without risking a repeat year.

But when I opened it, page after page was covered in beautifully neat handwriting—remarkably so for a first-year middle schooler.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Aaah... sorry, Ayumu-kun..."

I'll make sure to return it on Monday…
But for tonight, at least, I've got something to read.
Lost in fond memories of the past, I slowly turned the pages of the notebook.

Chapter 15: Entering a route

Monday.
I headed to school feeling a little antsy, and as usual, took a deep breath in front of the classroom door.
While I was looking forward to seeing Ayumu-kun, I also felt an inexplicable sense of unease.
When I see him, I just need to say "Good morning" like I normally would… right? Okay. I can do this!
I reached for the classroom door.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Eek?!"

I jumped at the unexpected voice behind me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez, Ayumu-kun, don't scare me like that—"

I turned around.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good morning."

And then I went completely still.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...A-Ayumu-kun...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. Hello."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…No way."

The words slipped out before I could stop myself. I was honestly that shocked.
Ayumu-kun cut his hair the day before yesterday.
And I distinctly remember getting all excited and telling him, "You look really good now." I remember that much.
But…
…Has he really always been this handsome…? HUUUH...?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…Nozomi-chan? Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…No, Ayumu-kun… um…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm glad... your injuries have healed…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I've still got a few bruises, though."

After awkwardly scratching his cheek, Ayumu-kun entered the classroom without a second thought.

I decided to go in after him.

Female student
"Oh, Nozomi, good— Huh?"

The girl who greeted me first froze in place.
Then, one after another, the students who looked over at us went completely still too.
Every one of them was standing there with their mouths open. They couldn't even utter a sound out of shock.

Nozomi Anesaki
"G-good mooorning..."

With the eyes of the entire class upon us, Ayumu-kun and I simultaneously took our seats.
Usually, my classmates would be crowding around me by now. Instead, they kept their distance, staring at Ayumu-kun in stunned silence.

Miho Orikasa
"Morning, Nozomi!"

Miho alone approached me with her usual cheerful energy, leaning close as though she were about to share a secret.

Miho Orikasa
"Wait, what? What's going on with the transfer student? Did something happen?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... well… I think he got a haircut."
Miho Orikasa
"Oohhh. A little makeover, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess."
Miho Orikasa
"Hmm... See? See? Just like I told you, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Miho Orikasa
"A total hottie."

I glanced over at Ayumu-kun.
Our eyes met.
He smiled at me, and I quickly looked away.
Y-yeah... I can't deny it. He really is a total hottie.

Miho Orikasa
"Oh my, oh my...?"

Miho gave me an exaggeratedly suspicious look.

Miho Orikasa
"Is this a premonition of love?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Idiot."

I played it cool and brushed off her teasing, but inside, I was freaking out.
My cheeks were burning. My heart was pounding. This feeling was similar to what I felt whenever I talked to Lord Wald.
I wasn't as dense as the protagonist of WataPuri.
Having played countless otome games, I immediately understood what these feelings of mine were.
Yes… there was absolutely no doubt…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I've entered a route…"
Miho Orikasa
"Huh? What? Are you talking about math first thing in the morning?"

I never imagined I'd ever want to romance a 3D man.

Chapter 16: A pair

After first period ended, Ayumu-kun left the classroom with his notebook and writing supplies. He was probably headed to the library.
Just as I was considering going to the library later myself, a few classmates started crowding around me, looking nervous.

Female student
"H-hey… is that really Kuraguchi-kun?"
Female student
"What happened to him…?"
Male student
"Man, I was not expecting that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha... yeah."

Well, naturally they'd be surprised.
Although I sympathised with everyone's reaction, I felt strangely proud.
I hoped this would make people a little less hostile toward Ayumu-kun.
…Unfortunately, it seems reality isn't anything like the 2D world.

Teacher
"Let's start today's three-minute English conversation practice. Get into groups of two or three."

It was our usual English Practice class.
Everyone got up and started forming groups, while Ayumu-kun remained sitting alone at his desk, staring off into space.

I guess the impression everyone had of him was too ingrained. His standing in the class seemed unchanged, no matter how different he looked.

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um, Miho…"
Miho Orikasa
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could Ayu— Could Kuraguchi-kun join us too?"
Miho Orikasa
"Huh? The transfer student? I don't mind."

Miho nodded, not seeming bothered in the slightest. Ahh, Miho… I really love you.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, Ayumu-kun."

My heart was beating a little faster as I went over to talk to him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... Nozomi-chan?"

Whoa, so dazzling.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come join us."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... Are you sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course, absolutely."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Thank you."

Ayumu-kun got to his feet with a bashful smile.
I suddenly felt someone watching me and turned around to find Miho looking at us with narrowed, suspicious eyes.

Miho Orikasa
"Guuuys..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Miho Orikasa
"Am I, like, third-wheeling here?"
Ayumu・Nozomi
"Huh?"
Miho Orikasa
" 'Ayumu-kun.' 'Nozomi-chan.' Since when did you two get so close that you're on a first-name basis?"

Ayumu･Nozomi
"!"

Sh-shoot… I let my usual habit slip. It's not like there was anything wrong with her finding out, but I felt kind of embarrassed.

Miho Orikasa
"I mean, it's fine, you know? I could go find someone else to partner with, if you want."
Nozomi Anesaki
"M-Miho, stop! Don't say things like that."
Miho Orikasa
"Hahaha, sorry, sorry! Just kidding. All right, transfer student! Hello."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... Ah! Hello."
Miho Orikasa
"Wow！Your pronunciation is really good!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Really？"
Miho Orikasa
"Oh, yes！！！"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wow, you two sure hit it off quickly…"

All in all, it was a fun three minutes.

There's another class on Monday that requires us to form groups.

Teacher
"All right, everyone, pair up!"

It was PE, and as usual, we started with our warm-up.

Teacher
"I'm going to set up the net, so make sure you all stretch properly!"

The teacher said it without a second thought, then disappeared into the PE storage room.
Hmm… Is Ayumu-kun going to be okay?
I stole a quick glance at the boys.

Miho Orikasa
"Aw, maaan… Looks like Gucchi is on his own again."

Miho shrugged dramatically.
For the record, "Gucchi" was a nickname she'd come up with during the English conversation exercise. Honestly, Miho's ability to make friends with practically anyone is something else.

Miho Orikasa

"Nozomi, why don't you pair up with him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Miho Orikasa
"One of the girls is absent today. If you pair up with Gucchi, we'll have an even number of people."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhhh..."

I guess she's right, but I'm still not sure...
As I hesitated over what to do, the teacher returned from the equipment room.

Teacher
"Oh? Kuraguchi's by himself again? Somebody pair up with him!"

The boys broke into raucous laughter.
.....
My hand shot up almost on its own.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll pair up with Kuraguchi-kun."

The room stirred with a faint murmur.
"Huh… seriously?"
"Anesaki-san? Why?"
"That's so nice of her…"
With everyone whispering around me, I calmly walked over and stood in front of Ayumu-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's do this, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…Nozomi-chan, I'm really sorry."

Ayumu-kun bowed his head, looking genuinely apologetic.
This feels awful... We're friends, so I wish he wouldn't look so sorry.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm teaming up with you because I want to."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Thank you."

That said, now that I think about it… stretching together with a guy… isn't that kind of embarrassing…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"U-um… wh-what should we do?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well..."

Ayumu-kun reached out his hand and lightly touched my shoulder.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uwah!!!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Whoa?! I'm... I'm sorry!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, no! Wait! It's okay! I was just a little startled, that's all!"

Idiot… Why is my heart racing like this...?
Lord Wald has hugged me before! He's even kissed me!
So why am I freaking out over something as little as him touching my shoulder?!

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Th-then… I'll go first."

Ayumu-kun stretched out his legs and sat down on the floor.
I took a moment to steady my racing heart before standing behind him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"How much pressure should I use?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You can press as hard as you want."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm, then… about this much?"

I leaned into Ayumu-kun's back, putting my weight against him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Maybe a little more..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay."

I pushed down on Ayumu-kun's back with even more force.
Oh, he is surprisingly flexible.
It was fun watching him sink lower and lower with every push, and I got carried away, pressing down on Ayumu-kun with more and more of my weight.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... um... Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-you don't have to press down quite so hard…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh! Sorry! Did I hurt you?!"

I hurriedly eased off the pressure. Then I heard people whispering around us.

Male student
"Whoa... Kuraguchi's got it good."
Male student
"Her boobs are definitely pressing against him."

！ ！ ！
I immediately jumped back, putting some distance between myself and him.
Then I dropped to the floor and repeatedly bowed in apology.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I'm so sorry… I'm really sorry…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"N-no… I'm… kind of sorry too…"

The stretching session came to an end, leaving behind an unbearably awkward atmosphere.

Chapter 17: A question to myself

Teacher
"...To calculate the area of the shaded region in this figure…"

The afternoon classes passed relatively peacefully.
Perhaps everyone was being overcome by sleepiness, because the classroom was unusually quiet.
I felt as though I might accidentally close my eyes too If I let my guard down, but falling asleep in class simply wasn't an option for a model student.
I fought off my drowsiness and kept writing equations in my notebook.
...Oh. I heard the sound of a pen moving from the desk beside me as well.
I glanced over and saw Ayumu-kun sitting there with a serious look on his face, focused on his notebook.
Ah, I love that look on his face.
Those beautiful eyes of his hadn't changed since our first year of middle school—the same eyes he had whenever he spoke about his dreams.
Surely Ayumu-kun wasn't writing equations in his notebook right now. He was probably working on some thrilling adventure story.

Teacher
"...So, Kuraguchi, can you give us the answer?"

Suddenly, the teacher called on him by name.
Ayumu-kun jerked his head up as if startled and hurriedly opened his textbook.
He really hadn't been paying attention to the lesson after all.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"U-um... it's..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"√3."

I whispered the answer under my breath.
Ayumu-kun's eyes widened for a split second before he quietly repeated the words to the teacher.

Teacher
"Correct. Take your seat."

He sat back down.
I returned Ayumu-kun's knowing glance with a warm smile.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."

After class ended, Ayumu-kun spoke to me again.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Thanks for earlier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're welcome. ...Ayumu-kun, you were writing your story, right?"

When I said that softly, his cheeks immediately turned red.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…How did you know…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You just looked like you were having fun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Y-yeah…"

Ayumu-kun cleared his throat and stood up from his seat.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well, I'm off to the library."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, see you later."

I waved goodbye to Ayumu-kun as he walked out of the classroom.
As soon as he left, several students approached me, looking somewhat uneasy.

Male student
"Nozomi-chan, are you close with Kuraguchi?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Male student
"Just because you're class rep doesn't mean you have to go out of your way to be friends with him, y'know?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no… it's not like I'm forcing myself…"
Male student
"Don't tell me the teacher put you up to it? Told you to be nice to him or something?"
Male student
"Whoa… seriously? Man, poor you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no, that's not it. It's really not like that."
Male student
"You're way too nice. I wonder if Kuraguchi even realizes it."
Female student
"He probably has the wrong idea."
Male student
"What an idiot. Someone like him has no business getting close to Anesaki-san."

I quietly clenched my fist in my lap.
Something dark slowly began to well up from deep inside me.
"Has no business getting close to me"? What is that supposed to mean?
They don't know the first thing about me. They don't know the first thing about Ayumu-kun, either.
What are these people even talking about?

Miho Orikasa
"Hey, guys, move over for a sec."

Suddenly, a voice rang out from beside us.
Miho squeezed her way in, dragging a chair behind her.

Miho Orikasa
"I'm having Nozomi explain that math problem from earlier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Miho Orikasa
"I need to concentrate, so scram! Come on, shoo!"

She waved her hand at them. They all left without a fuss, their faces saying, "There's no arguing with her."

Nozomi Anesaki
"…You don't actually need me to explain the math, do you?"
Miho Orikasa
"Oh, you figured it out?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not the type to spend your break studying, Miho."
Miho Orikasa
"Guilty. But hey, you're relieved now, right, Nozomi?"

That was true. Thanks to Miho, the anger that had been churning inside me until just moments ago was finally starting to subside.
If I had kept talking to everyone like that, I might have ended up showing them my true self.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you, Miho..."
Miho Orikasa
"Well, I was annoyed by it too, so I couldn't just sit there. I kinda had to step in."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Miho Orikasa
"Pretty much everyone in this class is like that. If you don't want things to turn into a fight, you just have to shrug it off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah..."

She was absolutely right.
If I want my school life to remain peaceful, then I have no choice but to keep my distance from Ayumu-kun and remain the "Nozomi Anesaki" I have always been.
I know that.
I know that, but...
Can I really be content with that…?

Chapter 18: Kokoro's cover

Teacher
"Goodbye."
Students
"Goodbye."

Another school day came to a peaceful end. A lot had happened, but all things considered, it had been relatively calm.
I was able to talk to Ayumu-kun normally, and I even managed to have a fairly good time. For now, maybe I should just keep things the way they are.
With that thought in mind, I packed my things into my bag.
…Then I noticed a black shopping bag inside.
…Oh! Right, right. I'd completely forgotten about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually… there's something I need to return to you…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? Something you need to return?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah."

I handed him the shopping bag containing the paperback and notebook.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"? What's this?"

As Ayumu-kun looked inside curiously, I leaned in close and whispered in a low voice.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Volume 10 of 'Grade X,' and that novel you wrote when you were younger."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, actually… I'd totally forgotten I had them. I guess I'd been holding onto them all this time…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What? Ah… ah! Oh, right… So that's what happened…! I'd completely forgotten too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm really sorry…!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, no, don't worry. I see... So that's what happened. I feel a little relieved now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And also, I read the novel in that notebook yesterday."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh... HUH?! Seriously?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, and... I found it really fun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh..."

I got so absorbed in reading that, before I knew it, I'd stayed up well into the night, long past the hour that was good for my skin.
Quite a few years had passed since I first read it, yet my impression of it remained unchanged.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It reminded me just how much I love your writing, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…I-I see…"

Ayumu-kun's eyes darted around restlessly.
There's no mistaking it… he's totally blushing, right? Could I have just raised his affection level?
As my otome-addled brain started running wild, Ayumu-kun continued in a quiet mumble.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I-I really..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I… really do... like you, Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Wh-what did you just say...?
W-wait a second...! Backlog! Backlog, please!

I really do... like you, Nozomi-chan…
.....
...Ky... K-KYAAAAAAA—!

Miho Orikasa
"What are you two lovebirds doing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah!"

Miho's remark brought me back to my senses. I realized that several people were standing a short distance away, staring at us with dumbfounded expressions.
I hurriedly stepped away from Ayumu-kun.
Then I forced a smile as though nothing had happened, and the stillness around us began to stir with quiet murmurs.

Male student
"Hey… Nozomi-chan, you're getting a little too friendly with Kuraguchi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Male student
"I was hoping you could help me with my studying."
Male student
"There is no student council meeting today, right?"

The boys came over, carrying their notebooks and study guides.
Ugh… what a hassle.
Trying not to let that feeling show on my face, I kept up a smile and awkwardly shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry... I've got something to take care of today..."
Male student
"Huh? Again?"
Male student
"That's all you ever say lately, Anesaki-san."

Male student
"Ever since Kuraguchi showed up, right?"

One of the boys pointedly glanced at Ayumu-kun.
He said nothing. He simply picked up his bag and the shopping bag and got to his feet.

Male student
"Hey, wait a sec."

The boys closed in around Ayumu-kun, blocking his way.
Wait… what's happening here…? Is this going to turn into another violent incident…?

Male student
"Hey, Kuraguchi…"

One of the boys pulled his hand out of his pocket.
Don't tell me...
I was just about to jump up and intervene when...

Male student
"So, what'd you get from Anesaki-san?"

The conversation took a turn I never saw coming.

Male student
"What's in that bag?"

Another boy deftly snatched the shopping bag from Ayumu-kun.
A chill ran through my entire body.
This is bad.
Bad. Really, really, really bad.
That bag contained a light novel and the novel Ayumu-kun had written.
Neither of them was something the people in this class would ever understand.
They absolutely must not see what's inside.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hold on… wait…!"

I shot to my feet, my voice coming out small and pathetic.
At the same moment, Ayumu-kun reached out and caught the wrist of the boy holding the shopping bag.

Male student
"...Why are you looking at me like that?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Male student
"Got a problem?"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. Give that back."

The strength in Ayumu-kun's voice was completely unlike his usual timid demeanor. He spoke each word clearly.

Male student
"Huuuh? No way."

The boy tried to shake his hand off.
But Ayumu-kun stubbornly held on and fought to take the shopping bag back.

Male student
"H-hey! Let go!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No."
Male student
"Ghk... let… go!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I said give it back."
Male student
"Damn it…! E-enough already!!!"

A dull thud echoed through the room.
A split second later, something came tumbling down with a flurry of rustling.
It all happened in an instant.
I didn't even have time to blink.
The black shopping bag hit the floor.
Its contents spilled out at the same time.
The paperback and notebook sprawled across the floor.
Every eye in the room turned toward those completely ordinary objects.

Male student
"? What's this? A study guide?"
Male student
"A notebook?"

The two boys picked up the paperback and the notebook.
There was nothing I could do anymore.
It's over. It's really over.
Those words repeated over and over in my mind, which had gone completely blank.

Male student
"Huh... so Anesaki-san has time to help Kuraguchi with his studying."
Male student
"Not fair."

The two boys grumbled as they started looking through the contents.

Ah. It's over. It's so over.

Male student
"...What?"
Male student
"What is this?"

The moment the two boys saw the contents, their faces went completely blank.
The boy holding the paperback quickly peeled off the outer cover.

Male student
"Huuh...?"

Just like that, the cover of "Grade X" was laid bare.
The students nearby gave it some rather dubious looks.

Male student
"Wait, what is that…? Some kind of otaku novel?"
Female student
"Yeah, it totally is… The cover looks just like one."
Male student
"This notebook's got some weird crap written in it, too."
Male student
"…But… why does Anesaki-san even have this stuff…?"

The suspicious gazes of the entire class pierced into me all at once.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I lowered my head in silence. I had reached a state of complete resignation.
I couldn't find a single excuse that could possibly cover for me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"These things..."

Suddenly, Ayumu-kun broke the silence.
His voice, clear and unwavering, carried through the classroom.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...belong to me."

...What?
I lifted my head.
Ayumu-kun glanced at me and smiled for just a moment before turning his gaze back toward the rest of the class.

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Both the book and the notebook are mine. I left them at school, and 'Anesaki-san' was just holding onto them for me."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So it's not like Anesaki-san and I are particularly close or anything."

As soon as Ayumu-kun finished speaking, the classroom once again erupted into whispers and murmurs.
The students' faces twisted with unpleasant smiles, like predators who had finally found the prey they wanted.

Male student
"Ooh, so that's it! I knew it!"
Male student
"Figures! There's no way Anesaki-san would read something like this!"
Male student
"Wait, so Kuraguchi really is an otaku after all!!!"

The classroom burst into a commotion.
The boys continued yammering on as they examined the paperback and notebook.

Male student
"Whoa... so this is one of those light novels? Gross."
Male student
"This novel looks like the delusional drivel of an otaku."
Male student
"So the stuff written in this notebook is Kuraguchi's fantasies? Ew..."
Male student
"Hey, lemme see that!"
Male student
"Whoa… it's cringe right from the opening!"

Laughter filled the entire classroom.
Ayumu-kun stood quietly at the center of it all.
His profile betrayed no particular emotion.
He wasn't angry, nor was he sad or embarrassed.
He merely stood there with a blank expression, staring absently at the classroom wall.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Is this really okay?
Is it really okay for things to stay this way?
Suppose everything settles here, just as it is now.
Ayumu-kun will go on being isolated in this class, just as he always has been.
And I'll keep being praised as the "flawless class representative who's kind to everyone—even otaku."
Nothing will change. Everything will stay the same.
Because Ayumu-kun protected me, I can continue to hold on to my current position.

But...
Is this really what I want?

Teacher
"Someone please let Kimura-san join your group."
Female student
"...Uh..."
Female student
"Then… let's decide with rock-paper-scissors…"
Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Male student
"Ughhh. I ended up next to Kimura."
Male student
"Gyahaha, this sucks."
Nozomi Kimura
"..."

I don't hate being fawned over.
Because it feels good.
I'd much rather be liked by everyone than looked down on.
That's only natural, right?
I don't want anyone to find out I'm an otaku. I don't want to be made fun of.
I don't want to throw away the position I've worked so hard to build for myself.
However…

Male student
"This novel is garbage. You should learn a thing or two from Natsume Sōseki."

Crack. Something inside me snapped.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey."

My voice came out surprisingly calm.
The noisy classroom fell silent in an instant.
That's right.
This is the kind of presence "Nozomi Anesaki" has.
Whenever I say something, everyone goes quiet and listens.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I felt like my legs were trembling. I could feel the tremor in my throat, too.
I was still hesitating. I was afraid. I had simply too much to lose.
But still...

Nozomi Anesaki

"That book and notebook are mine."

I decided to rip my cover off once and for all.
.....
For a moment, everyone fell silent. They probably didn't understand what I meant by what I'd just said.
Only Ayumu-kun stared back at me, his eyes wide with shock.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan… what are you saying...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm the one who brought them."

I said it again, this time more clearly.
I could feel the whole class staring at me, their stunned gazes practically clinging to my skin.
A shiver ran through me, but I stood my ground, planting both feet firmly beneath me.
It's all right. I'm prepared. I've come this far. There is no way I'm going back now.

Male student
"Anesaki-san… what are you talking about…?"
Male student
"You're not serious..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I am. Ayumu-kun lied to you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, I—"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I brought that. So I want it back."

I cut Ayumu-kun off and held up my palm toward the two boys. The classroom began to buzz with chatter again.

Male student
"Uh... But… this is a light novel, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Male student
"Anesaki-san, you actually read stuff like this…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I do."

So what?
With a smug look on my face, I snatched the book and notebook from the boys.
It was a rough, forceful gesture that probably no one could have imagined coming from the usual "Nozomi Anesaki."

Male student
"Ah… oh! I-I get it now!"

One of the boys exclaimed, visibly flustered.
I narrowed my eyes at him, and he went on with a nervous grin.

Male student
"You're just covering for Kuraguchi, right?"
Male student
"Oh… ohhh, I see…"
Male student
"There's no way Anesaki-san would actually read something like this…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Would it really be so strange if I read books like this?"
Male student
"Huh? Uh… yeah."
Male student
"Because this is the kind of novel otaku read, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then there's nothing strange about it."
Male students
"Huh?"

The three of them tilted their heads in confusion.
I made my voice even more resolute, addressing not just them, but everyone in the classroom.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I am an otaku."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And I love light novels, anime, and video games!"

The classroom fell completely silent.
I put the book and notebook back into the shopping bag and carried it in one hand along with my schoolbag.
No one said or did a thing while I was doing it.
They just stood there in stunned silence, watching my every move.
In the end, I quietly left the classroom and no one tried to stop me.

Chapter 19: When the magic wears off

.....
.....
...Ah...
Aah...
Aaaaaaaaah...

Male student
"Oh, Vice President Anesaki. Goodbye."
Female student

"Bye-bye, Nozomi!"

The students passing by waved at me.
I wasn't sure if I was managing to smile back properly.
Surely, when tomorrow comes, they will all look at me differently.
Aah...
A—

Nozomi Anesaki
"I really went and did it…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Ah, Anesaki-san. Are you heading home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... Hoshina-senpai..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"...Hm? Is something wrong? You look a little down..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm all right... See you…"
Mizuho Hoshina
"Sure…? Take care, okay…?"

Ah… even Hoshina-senpai's smile looks hazy to me now…
It might be the last time I ever see it, too. What a shame…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home..."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, welcome back, Sis."

Ugh… Shun's already home…
For some reason, I couldn't bring myself to meet his eyes, so I instinctively looked down.

Shun Anesaki
"? Huh? What happened?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing…"
Shun Anesaki
"Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."

I gave him a curt reply and headed straight to my room.
As soon as I collapsed onto my bed, I heard a knock at the door.
…Shun really is sharp.
I rolled over to face the wall and spoke up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come in."

The door opened.
I heard Shun's footsteps draw closer, then come to a complete stop just behind me.

Shun Anesaki
"…Did something happen?"

There was an unusual seriousness in his voice.
I was quiet for a moment, then spoke without turning around.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sorry."

I could sense Shun go still.
He couldn't possibly know what had happened from those few words alone.
But he didn't press me for an explanation. Instead, he quietly exhaled and sat down beside me.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"I don't know what happened, but…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"I'll be fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"So..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm."
Shun Anesaki
"Don't regret it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. I don't regret it."
Shun Anesaki
"...I see. Good, then."

Silence settled over us once again.
Neither of us said a word or even looked at each other, we just stayed there together in the same room.

After a while, the doorbell rang.
Usually, we'd argue about who was going to answer it, but this time Shun simply got up and went without saying anything.
I slowly closed my eyes.
The events in the classroom earlier began to replay in my mind.
I didn't regret what I'd done.
And yet, when I thought about what lay ahead, an indescribable sense of emptiness washed over me.

Chapter 20: Together

A faint noise stirred me, and I opened my eyes.
From the hallway beyond the door came the sound of two people approaching.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."

I heard Shun's voice. Before I could answer, he continued.

Shun Anesaki
"Lord Wald is here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"

I instinctively rolled over and raised my head.
A moment later, the door to my room opened.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!"

I immediately turned back around so that my back was facing Ayumu-kun. I didn't want him to see the look on my face.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

The footsteps drew closer.
I heard his shallow breathing and realized he'd probably run all the way here.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."

His footsteps stopped right behind me. I instinctively curled in on myself.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Turn this way."

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No."

I forced out a quiet reply. When I heard the faint tremor in my voice, I silently cursed myself.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hey."

Suddenly, I felt a hand press against my shoulder.
Unable to resist the pull from behind, I turned over on the bed.
My vision was blurred, but I could make out Ayumu-kun staring straight at me.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I knew it... you're crying."

At those words, the tears came pouring out, as if a dam had broken.
Why did this have to happen?
I had been holding it together just fine when Shun was here.
But the moment I saw Ayumu-kun's face, something I couldn't explain welled up inside me, and before I knew it, my eyes were filling with tears.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan…"

Ayumu-kun's voice was slightly lower than usual. For some reason, he looked a little angry, too.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Why would you do that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nothing you did was going to change my position in class. So why did you say that?"

…He was right.
No matter what I'd done, Ayumu-kun's position in the class wouldn't have changed.
I hadn't helped him at all. I'd only jeopardized my own standing.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"If this is what it was going to do to you… you shouldn't have said those things."

It was a pained admission, almost a groan.
That was when I realized that Ayumu-kun and I saw what had happened very differently.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't regret it."

I was telling the truth.
I hesitated at the time. I was afraid.
But once I'd let everything out, I didn't have any regrets anymore.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't think what I did was wrong."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Then why are you crying?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's because..."

I think...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I was relieved."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think I finally felt at ease when you came."

I wasn't sad. Not at all.
If anything, what bloomed in my heart when I saw his face was warmth.
Back in my first year of middle school, there was always one boy beside me.
Every day when I got to school, he was the only one who would say "good morning" to me.
Whenever we had to work in pairs, I was always with him.
I started going to school every day, even though I'd used to miss it so often.
Neither of us would skip school just because of a mere cold.
So I never had to be alone at school.
And now, once again, Ayumu-kun was here beside me.
That made me happy.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you."

I wiped my tears away with my sleeve and gave him a small smile.
Ugh… My nose is running. This is so embarrassing.
…Oh, well. It's just Ayumu-kun.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

For a moment, Ayumu-kun just stared at me with wide eyes, clearly bewildered. Then he broke into laughter, as though he couldn't hold it back any longer.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…Pfft… haha… What is it with you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? My nose…?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? No…! I mean, yeah, that's funny too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's just… everything about you right now is kind of funny."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hahaha… I see… Yeah. …If you're okay with it, then that's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…But seriously, why did you say all that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Because… I was angry. It was as simple as that."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was angry at them for mocking everything."

The light novel. The story he'd written.
...And Ayumu-kun himself, too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Because... it's what I truly love."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

I picked up the shopping bag from the floor and held it out to Ayumu-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"So… please, don't ever stop."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't ever stop doing what you love, Ayumu-kun. Keep going."

Even if other people laugh at him, even if no one understands him.
I want to be the one person who does.
And I don't want Ayumu-kun to reject these feelings I hold.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Okay."

Ayumu-kun smiled and took the shopping bag from me.
Then, in one smooth motion, he pulled me into his arms.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I will..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'll go to school tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah…?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm definitely going."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So you come to school too, okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah!"

I nodded without hesitation and hugged Ayumu-kun back.
I knew that even from tomorrow on, I wouldn't have to be alone.

Happy end: Two as one

The next morning.
I arrived at school just before the bell and stopped in front of the classroom door.
I pulled out my compact mirror and checked my appearance one more time.
…Though perhaps I don't need to anymore. Still, it was more or less a habit by now, and I don't see myself breaking it anytime soon.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."

I clenched my fist and took one deep breath.
With a burst of courage, I reached for the door...

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

But I froze, my body still tense.
Only then did I notice the faint trembling in my hand. …Hahaha. This is pathetic.
It reminded me of the old days.
I remember standing outside the classroom just like this, taking a deep breath every morning.
It took all the courage I had to take that first step inside.
…It's okay. Don't be afraid.
I'm not alone, after all.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...!"

This time, I braced myself and looked straight ahead.
Then, with all the strength I could muster, I opened the door.

Nozomi Kimura
"..."
Students
"..."
Nozomi Kimura
(…Ah. Of course…)
???
"Nozomi-chan!"
Nozomi Kimura
"...Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Morning."

A clear, calm voice rang out.
In the quiet classroom, it reached straight into my heart, unhindered by anything else.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning...!"

I called out in a strong voice and firmly stepped into the room.
And then the classroom filled with voices from every direction.

Female student
"Nozomi-chan, good morning."
Male student
"Good morning."
Female student

"Mooorning!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

...Huh?
I took my seat, completely dumbfounded.
Miho greeted me right away, like usual.

Miho Orikasa
"Morning, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"...Heey!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah! Y-yeah. Morning..."
Miho Orikasa
"…Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Uh... no..."

What...? What is going on...?
It was an ordinary morning, no different from any other. And that was exactly what felt so strange.
Because yesterday…

Nozomi Anesaki
"I am an otaku."

I said all those things yesterday, and everyone in the class must have heard me loud and clear.
So I don't understand... Why is everything so peaceful this morning? Was it all just a dream…?

Miho Orikasa
"Still, yesterday was quite a surprise, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...!"

My body tensed at Miho's sudden remark.
So it really wasn't a dream after all…

Miho Orikasa
"Your coming-out really shocked me yesterday, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"Can't believe you slipped right past my radar… Impressive."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...U-um..."
Miho Orikasa
"Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're not weirded out by it…?"
Miho Orikasa
"...Huuh?"

Miho let out a startled, high-pitched cry.
I fidgeted and looked away, and an exaggerated sigh followed.

Miho Orikasa
"…Aww, I'm huuurt…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Miho Orikasa
"I'm seriously offended that you thought this would weird me out."
Miho Orikasa
"And you thought I was the kind of person who'd turn my back on you over something like that? That hurts even more."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... N-no, I mean… but… you know?"
Miho Orikasa
" 'You know?' Don't give me that. Honestly… what a stupid thing to worry about. How many decades do you think we've been friends?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… not decades. It's only been a year and a few months."
Miho Orikasa
"Ah… right. Huh. That's… surprisingly little…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"..."
Miho・Nozomi
"Pfft!"

We looked at each other and burst out laughing at the same time.
Yeah… Miho was still Miho.
We'd only been friends for a little over a year, yet somehow it felt like we'd been best friends forever.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What a relief… honestly…"
Miho Orikasa
"…Sure, this class can be a bit much sometimes, but you should carry yourself with a little more confidence."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yeah. But…"

I glanced around the room, and my eyes met with a few of my classmates.
I tensed for a moment, but they simply smiled back at me, just like always.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh… Everyone's acting pretty normal…"
Miho Orikasa
"Ahh… well…"

Miho gave me a sly grin.

Miho Orikasa
"Maybe we have Gucchi to thank for that?"
Ayumu・Nozomi
"Huh?"

Apparently Ayumu-kun had overheard us, and our voices overlapped.
We both stared at her in confusion, but Miho continued with a smirk.

Miho Orikasa
"I think everyone was moved by Gucchi's magnificent speech… or should I say… his passionate, heartfelt declaration of love?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"W-wait, Orikasa-san...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What? What do you mean?"
Miho Orikasa
"Oh, you see, you see…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Wait! Please! S-seriously, stop!"

Ayumu-kun's face was bright red as he frantically leaned toward us, but Miho ignored him and whispered into my ear.

Miho Orikasa
"So, after you left yesterday..."

Male student
"H-hey... what was that...?"
Male student
"Anesaki-san's an otaku? Seriously?"
Female student
"No waaay! I don't believe it."
Male student
"That can't be true. This is Anesaki-san we're talking about."
Female student
"She's probably just covering for Kuraguchi-kun."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...No."
Students
"...Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I don't think Nozomi-chan was trying to protect me."
Male student
"Huuh? What the hell are you talking about?"
Male student
"Then what? You're saying Anesaki-san really is an otaku?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah."
Students
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"She is. Everything Nozomi-chan said earlier was true."
Students
"…No way…"
Students
"Anesaki-san...?"
Students
"Huh... It can't be..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What's wrong with that?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Do you all hate Nozomi-chan now? Just because she's an otaku?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Are you going to turn against her? Does this really change who Nozomi-chan is to you? She's still the same person, isn't she?"
Students
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Personally... I love Nozomi-chan. I love her a lot."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Otaku or not, I'll always feel the same about her."

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi!!! I LOVE YOU!!! MARRY ME!!!"
Miho Orikasa
"...Gucchi shouted at the top of his lungs."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, I did not say that."
Miho Orikasa
"Yeah, sorry. The last part was a lie. But everything before that was true."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...It was... Jeez... Why did you have to tell her…?"
Miho Orikasa
"Oh, come on. It was pretty cool, if you ask me. I'm sure everyone was really moved by it."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Ayumu-kun turned away, like he couldn't bring himself to look at me.
As I watched his profile, I couldn't keep the silly grin from spreading across my face.
Oh, gosh… He really said that. He meant it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, I love you so much!!!"

AYUMU EPILOGUES

Epilogue 1: Rocket launchers and a girl's ♥

Something isn't right.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hey, Shun-kun, can we lay off the rocket launchers next time?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh? Why? You're still mad about earlier, Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, not at all. I just thought it'd be fun to play with a few weapon restrictions."
Shun Anesaki
"Ahh, I'm down. Then no grenades either."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"And no rifles."
Shun Anesaki
"You know what? Let's just ban all ranged weapons."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"So, just knives?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. …Actually, let's ditch knives too."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? So no weapons at all?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yep. Pure hand-to-hand combat."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hahaha, sounds good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Shun and Ayumu-kun were engrossed in the game, happily chatting away.
This has been going on for nearly an hour now.
And I've spent that entire time silently watching the two of them.
…This isn't how it was supposed to be. For starters, how did things even end up like this?

Ayumu-kun came over to hang out this afternoon, and at first, the two of us were just relaxing together in my room.
For some reason, Shun came along. The next thing I knew, we were playing games in his room. And somehow, that became the three of us playing an action game.
I don't know how we got on that track, but so far, so good.
But when I stopped playing and just watched, the two of them somehow started getting more and more into it.
And before I knew it, they'd completely forgotten about me and were off in their own little world.
…This is weird, right? I can't be the only one who thinks this way.
I mean, I'm the one who made plans to hang out with Ayumu-kun today! And, uh, hello? I'm his girlfriend, aren't I?
So why am I, his actual girlfriend, the one being left out while my younger brother Shun, who has nothing to do with any of this, is getting all cozy with Ayumu-kun?
This is wrong. This is definitely wrong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey!"

It was the first time I'd spoken in an hour.
Shun and Ayumu-kun froze, then turned toward me with surprised looks on their faces.
Their expressions practically said, "Oh yeah, she was here."
Grrr!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you guys planning to play all day?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? Oh… what should we do?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, what time are you going home?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm... I dunno."
Shun Anesaki
"Why don't you stay for dinner?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh, is it okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"It is, it is. That means we've got plenty of time."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. We can keep playing."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

W-wait, wait… Whoa, whoa, whoa, whoa, whoa… Since when do you two get to make plans all by yourselves…?
"Why don't you stay for dinner?"... That's not your line to say.

And you're still planning to play games? Until dinner?
So I'm just going to be completely ignored until then? No way. Absolutely not.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun!"

This time, I called him by name.
Ayumu-kun turned around in surprise, and I decided to make a point of reminding him that I was his girlfriend.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I am sooooo bored right now."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... Oh! I'm sorry! I'm really sorry, Nozomi-chan!"

Ayumu-kun hastily bowed his head in apology.
Yeah... Ayumu-kun gets it. Well, that's all that matters… as long as he notices me…
I smiled at him all lovestruck, my earlier irritation completely forgotten, and Ayumu-kun readjusted his grip on the controller…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Just wait until this match is over!"

And then he turned back to the screen.

Shun Anesaki
"Next round's the real deal."
Ayumu・Shun
"It's a hand-to-hand battle!"

.....
Grrr!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"HAAAND-TO-HAAAAND COMBAT?! ARE YOU KIDDING ME?!"

I found myself on my feet, yelling from the depths of my stomach.
Shun and Ayumu-kun jumped in surprise, dropping their controllers.
I glared at the two of them as they looked up at me, completely dumbfounded, and bellowed:

Nozomi Anesaki
"A MILITARY GAME!!! AND YOU'RE NOT EVEN USING WEAPONS?! THAT'S HERESY!!!"

Go play a fighting game instead!!!
I said my piece, then stomped out of Shun's room.

Ayumu・Shun
"..."

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Heresy... is it?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Damn... She's got a point..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I'm in big trouble, aren't I?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, big time."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Sorry, Shun-kun. I've gotta go apologize to her. We'll play again another time."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Good luck."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeeez! Ayumu-kun, you dummy!!!"

I flopped onto the bed and immediately reached for the game console.
Fine. Whatever. I don't care about Ayumu-kun anymore. I'll just go be lovey-dovey with Lord Wald instead!

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan."

I heard Ayumu-kun's flustered voice from outside the room.
I decided to give him the silent treatment and kept pressing the buttons on my game console.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chaan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Can I come in?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm coming in, okay...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Sorry… I'm coming in, all right? Coming in…"

After announcing himself several times, Ayumu-kun nervously stepped into the room.
I kept pretending to play my game, but my entire attention was fixed on him.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I-I'm sorry, Nozomi-chan..."

Ayumu-kun stood by the bed, sounding terribly sorry as he spoke to me.
I glanced up at him, and he looked like he was about to cry.
...That kind of got to me.
But that wasn't enough to make me forgive him just yet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's fine. You can keep playing with Shun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll just have fun with Lord Wald instead."

With that, I turned my attention back to the game.
Ayumu-kun showed no sign of leaving. But he didn't say anything to me, either.
His presence made me feel increasingly restless, but I decided to keep playing for now.

Wald
"Nozomi, I'm sorry… Please don't be angry with me."
Nozomi
"..."
Wald
"I was in the wrong. Won't you please cheer up...?"
Nozomi
"…Then… may I ask you to grant me a favor…?"
Wald
"Of course. Anything you wish."
Nozomi
"…Please kiss me."
Wald
"Hahaha. Really, is that all? That's an easy request, my sweet princess."

Ahhh… Lord Wald is just wonderful…!
He actually understands a girl's heart. I guess I have no choice but to forgive him…!
He's nothing like a certain someone I know.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hooonestly… Ayumu-kun could really learn a thing or two from him."

I murmured pointedly, all while casually shifting my gaze toward Ayumu-kun…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Eek!!! His face… is terrifying!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"...A-Ayumu-kun...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"If I kiss you like Lord Wald did, will you stop being mad?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, yeah. Wait, WHAT?!"

Before I even had time to think, Ayumu-kun's face was suddenly right in front of me.
I quickly shut my eyes and braced myself.
Come to think of it, I've never actually kissed anyone in real life before.
Wh-what do I do, what do I do?! What is it going to feel like…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...?"

…Nothing's happening. Huh…?
I cautiously opened my eyes, only to see Ayumu-kun right in front of me, his face completely red.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I-I can't..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's just... I don't really know… how I'm supposed to do this…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"T-the angle… Like, the way we're positioned… Should we stay like this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

What the heck was that?
All the tension left me, leaving me staring at Ayumu-kun in bewilderment. He seemed to brace himself, his grip on my shoulders growing firmer.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…O-okay. I'm doing it, okay? I'm just going for it, yeah? Is that fine? We're good?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"You're totally killing the mood."

I muttered curtly, shutting him down.
Ayumu-kun's shoulders slumped in defeat, and he pulled away from me slightly.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm sorry..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You really should be."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan… Could you lend me an otome game sometime?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'll do a little more studying first… So…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"

For a split second, I felt something warm brush against my cheek.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"This is my apology for today... Please cheer up..."

Ayumu-kun whispered, his face still flushed bright red.
Oh… right, I was mad at him until just a moment ago…
That realization alone was enough to show just how completely my anger had faded.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(Ah...)
Shun Anesaki
(I wanna fire a rocket launcherrrrr!)

Epilogue 2: The Wald War

A few weeks had passed since Nozomi came out as an otaku.
Since then, the number of Nozomi's die-hard fans had certainly seemed to dwindle, but apparently, she had gained a new following to make up for it.
Despite the changes her confession had brought to her school life, things around Nozomi had settled into a peaceful new normal.
The girl who had once been so nervous and hesitant now stood happily beside her boyfriend, a bright smile on her face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, did you watch 'Slow World' yesterday?"

…See? Like this.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I did, I did. The plot was a little different from the source material, wasn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you think they're gonna start doing original anime content now?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah… They're almost caught up with the light novel, after all."

They were keeping their voices low, evidently wary of drawing attention, but their conversation would have been perfectly clear to anyone who knew the subject matter.
From what I could tell, they were talking about a light-novel adaptation that was airing this season.
There were all kinds of otaku, but these two were probably your average anime, manga, and light novel fans.
And there was one more thing…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, speaking of which, I made it to chapter five of WataPuri."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?! How was it? Isn't Lord Wald amazing?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. Lord Wald's definitely cool."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Riiight?"
Miho Orikasa
"..."

It sounded interesting... so interesting... I wanted to join in so badly…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"But I actually like the protagonist's friend the most."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Anita?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Isn't that a female character?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I know, but… she's cute, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You sure like your tsundere girls, don't you, Ayumu-kun…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ugh... but, you know… Anita… she reminds me of you a little, Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"?! HUH?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what are you saying?! Cut it out! That's not true! I'm the protagonist, remember?!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah… haha. Right, you are…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez..."
Miho Orikasa
"..."

I just couldn't bring myself to join in...
I had yet to come out to Nozomi.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, Miho, ready to head home?"
Miho Orikasa
"Ah. Sorry, Nozomi. You two go on ahead today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh? Aren't you off from club today, Miho?"
Miho Orikasa
"I am, but... I have some shopping to do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Then we'll come with you! Right, Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, sure. I was thinking about stopping by the bookstore anyway."
Miho Orikasa
"Ah… but it could take a while, so you don't have to bother."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?"
Miho Orikasa
"I'd hate to get in the way of you two."
Ayumu・Nozomi
"Uh..."
Miho Orikasa
"Hehehe, well then. Have fun on your after-school date."

Miho gave us a quick wave and hurried out of the classroom. Was she in a rush for some reason?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, Ayumu-kun, shall we head home?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. Oh, can we stop by the bookstore?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure."

Female student
"Bye-bye, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Bye-bye."
Male student
"See you later, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, see you."

Even after my otaku side became common knowledge, everyone continued to treat me exactly as they always had.
Actually, I'd even made new friends, and my life was becoming more fulfilling than it had been before.
And also...

Male student
"Hey, Kuraguchi. Can I come over and play 'Dead Monitor' at your place sometime?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, sure."
Male student
"I'll return that manga I borrowed tomorrow."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Got it."

Ayumu-kun, too, seemed to have made friends outside our class. He looked like he was enjoying school life much more than before.
As happy as I was about it, sometimes they'd get excited talking about games I'd never played, and I couldn't help feeling a little left out.
…Though really, I have no right to complain about something like that.
Just being able to spend time with Ayumu-kun again, like we did back in our first year of middle school, was practically a miracle in itself.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What is it?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You seem a little down. Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Do I really look that way?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah… Listen… are you really sure this was the right thing to do…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Here we go again."

I brushed off Ayumu-kun's worried question with a smile.
He'd asked me the same thing several times since I came out as an otaku.
Apparently, he still wasn't convinced that this new life suited me better than the one I'd had before.
Even though I'd denied it time and time again.
I'm dating him because I want to be with him.

I want to stand by his side as the person I really am.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I really don't regret anything. If anything, I think I'm much happier with how things are now."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Really…? But sometimes you look a little unhappy, Nozomi-chan… so I was a bit concerned."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh… th-that's…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm… a little jealous, I guess. Or maybe… I've just been feeling lonely."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I mean… you just seemed like you were having more fun talking to those guys earlier…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh… you think so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... Even when it comes to games, you seem to enjoy yourself so much more when you're playing games with Shun than with me…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I get it... I mostly play otome games these days… so maybe our tastes just don't line up that well…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess I should actually take the time to learn about the games you guys are so into."

Though, honestly, I still don't really see the appeal…

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan… you really don't have to worry about something like that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Something like that…?"

It's kind of a big deal to me, though.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I don't think being close to someone means you have to get involved in every aspect of their life."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... that might be true..."

Still, I think the more you have in common with someone you love, the better.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Well… I really get where you're coming from, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I want to know as much about you as I can, too. And I want to grow to love the things you love."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Ugh… sometimes Ayumu-kun just drops the most outrageous lines like it's nothing… I'm sure he doesn't even realize he's doing it. Maybe that's what makes them hit even harder.

Nozomi Anesaki
"B-but you don't have to force yourself to get into my interests or anything…!"

He probably wasn't even interested in WataPuri in the first place. And yet he'd been playing it just to keep me happy. The thought made me feel terribly guilty.
…It dawned on me then.
I see… So this must be how Ayumu-kun feels when I say things like that.
Even if Ayumu-kun and I don't like all the same things, that doesn't change what we have. That's why he told me I didn't need to worry about it.
So… that means Ayumu-kun likes me for me, not because we happen to share the same interests… right…?
I'd always thought the things we had in common were what held us together most strongly. But now I could feel that we'd built something deeper—a trust between us that had nothing to do with our shared hobbies. And realizing that made me incredibly happy.

When we got to the bookstore, Ayumu-kun immediately started looking for the book he'd come for.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm… no luck…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's not here?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. I had a feeling this bookstore might not have it… and it looks like I was right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Should we try another bookstore?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan, aren't you getting bored?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nope, not at all. Where should we go next?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hmm… We could try the bookstore by the station… Oh, actually, Animart* might be better."

*Likely a reference to the Japanese retail chain Animate.
Nozomi Anesaki
"Animart…? That's near the station too, right?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. Have you been there before, Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No."

I knew that Animart was a store that specialized in anime, manga, and game-related merchandise.
I'd always been curious about the store whenever I passed by it, but I didn't have the courage to go in by myself, and I was afraid that someone I knew might see me going in. I could never quite bring myself to enter.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Have you ever been there, Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. They've got a much bigger selection of light novels and stuff, and they keep more of them in stock than a regular bookstore."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Also, I think they're doing a WataPuri fair right now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…Wanna go check it out?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"YES...!"

And so, my first-ever visit to Animart.

Nozomi Anesaki
"!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ahaha, you look like you're having fun."

When he laughed at me like that, I realized I must have been making a pretty ridiculous expression.
But I was in no state to put on a straight face.
I was desperately holding back the urge to scream and roll around on the floor right then and there.
To my right: Lord Wald.
To my left: Lord Wald.

Behind me: Lord Wald!!!
How was I supposed to stay calm in a situation like this?

Nozomi Anesaki
"A-Ayumu-kun… did you find the book you were looking for…?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah, I already paid for it. Did you find anything you liked, Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… there's a lot."

The WataPuri section takes up a pretty big chunk of the store.
They've got all the merch I already own, naturally, but there's also tons of stuff I've never seen before.
I'd love to collect every Lord Wald item here, but… I don't have that much money on me right now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Lord Wald's body pillow... is so expensive..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Pfft!"

Ayumu-kun suddenly spat out his drink.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"A body pillow?! You're seriously buying that?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Too cringe?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, it's fine… It just gives me mixed feelings…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahh… This figure is adorable…! Huh? Is it not available yet?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ohh, looks like it's a prize for Animart's exclusive lottery. It starts this Saturday… oh, that's the day after tomorrow."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm participating. No question."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I hear people start lining up early in the morning. It sounds pretty intense."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, is that so?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'll queue with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun..."

What a gorgeous guy…

Nozomi Anesaki

"Hmm… Then maybe I'll save my real shopping for the day after tomorrow and just buy this charm today."

Just as I picked up the item and turned the corner at the end of the aisle...

Nozomi・???
"Whoa!"

I suddenly collided with someone who appeared in front of me, and my body was knocked backward.
I heard something hit the floor.
Then I slowly opened my eyes, and standing right in front of me was...

Miho Orikasa
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Mi... ho...?"

It's her, right? There's no mistaking it…

Miho Orikasa
"...Ah... Nozomi... and... Gucchi... it's you…"

Miho was always so outspoken, so seeing her stumble over her words was unusual.
Her reaction struck me as strange, and then I remembered where we were, which only made me more confused.
This was Animart, after all—a specialty store for anime, manga, and game-related merchandise.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh…? Orikasa-san…? What are you doing here…?"

Ayumu-kun voiced the very question I was thinking.
Miho fidgeted, her eyes drifting uneasily toward the floor, before silently backing away a few steps.
As I carefully followed her movements with my eyes, something suddenly caught my attention.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's... WataPuri merch… right…?"

There were two charms in her hand: the Lord Wald one I'd been about to buy myself, and another character's.
They were completely at odds with Miho's usual image, yet they rested securely in one of her hands.

Miho Orikasa
"..."

Miho was still nervously darting her eyes around, looking awfully suspicious.
So... does this mean... what I think it means?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho… you're a WataPuri fan…?"

Silence.

Miho Orikasa
"...Y-yeah."

Miho gave a small, resigned nod.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha… what…? You should've told me sooner…!"

Miho had actually been around once when Ayumu-kun and I were talking about WataPuri. But she just smiled and told us, "Don't mind me. Keep talking," without showing even the slightest interest in the topic.
So I'd always assumed Miho was just an ordinary person who had nothing to do with the otaku world.

Miho Orikasa
"Sorry… I just couldn't bring myself to say it…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're too secretive…"

I mean, sure, I could understand her not wanting an ordinary person to know. But why me? I'm an otaku, too. We even like the same kinds of things.
Well… it seems Miho doesn't want anyone at school to know. I can definitely understand why she'd be cautious about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I won't tell anyone else about this, so don't worry."
Miho Orikasa
"Yeah... Thanks..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Honestly, I still can't quite believe it.."

I was genuinely amazed. But even more than that, I felt a growing sense of joy.
Loving the same thing as your best friend is honestly such a wonderful feeling.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho, you like Lord Wald too?"
Miho Orikasa
"I-I do..."

Miho laughed, though her eyes kept wandering down to the ground.
She's been doing that for a while now.
I couldn't help following her gaze, and when I looked down, I noticed a booklet at my feet.
Come to think of it, I vaguely remember hearing something hit the ground when Miho and I bumped into each other earlier.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Is this yours, Miho?"

The moment I crouched down and picked up the booklet, Miho let out a shriek.

Miho Orikasa
"No...!'
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

At the sharp, tense sound of her voice, I stopped dead in my tracks.
But I'd already gotten a clear look at it.

Image:
"Midnight Executive Meeting"

The kiss between Lord Wald and Melchior—
.....
...Huh? A kiss?
Why? Why are they kissing?
Lord Wald is a man, isn't he?
And Melchior is a man too, right?
Wh-why...?
Why are two men... kissing...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"…H-homo…"

I whispered.
Miho visibly flinched.
It was only then that I finally understood why Miho had kept her hobby a secret from me.

Everything that happened afterward was a blur.
I watched Miho's back disappear as she practically fled the scene, then left Animart with Ayumu-kun.
I vaguely remember him talking to me the whole way, but I hardly registered any of it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

When I got home, the first thing I did was boot up the game.

Wald
I love you, Nozomi...

Right?
Lord Wald loves me, not some—
No... No, no, no, no...!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Lord Wald is *not* gay..."

That night, I drifted off into a restless sleep.

When I arrived at school, Miho was already there.
What do I do...? After what happened yesterday, I don't know how I'm supposed to face her.
I nervously made my way over to my desk.
Miho seemed to notice me and looked up.
Our eyes met, and there was a brief pause.

Nozomi Anesaki
"M-morning."

My voice came out awkwardly, but at least I managed to get the words out.

Miho Orikasa
"...Morning..."

Miho replied in much the same way, sounding strangely distant and unlike herself.
Neither of us seemed able to find a way to keep the conversation going, and before long, we were both sitting there in silence.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good morning."

Ayumu-kun arrived at school looking as relaxed as ever.
I felt relieved. I was hoping someone would come along and break the suffocating silence between us.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hello. Good morning to you too, Orikasa-san."
Miho Orikasa
"...Good morning."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, right! Yesterday, I cleared Lord Wald's route all the way to the end—"

Jolt! Miho and I both flinched at the same time.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Ah..."

Ayumu-kun had finally noticed the awkward tension between Miho and me.
After fumbling for words for a while, he finally said:

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...I'm kind of hungry..."

With that awkward little mutter, he took his seat.
After that, none of us could find a way to start a conversation, and the heavy atmosphere lingered until the bell rang.
And then, during English Practice...

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"..."

As usual, the three of us formed a group, which was all well and good, but...
...This is so awkward...! The atmosphere is suffocating...!
Ayumu-kun looked at me helplessly, silently begging me to do something, but I was at a loss myself.
Miho was always the one to break the tension when things got this awkward, but today, that very Miho looked positively miserable.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...U-um... okay, then, I'll read Emma's part..."

Just act normal. That's all I have to do. As for yesterday's... incident... I'll pretend I never saw it. I should be able to do that.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Th-then I'll be Tom."
Miho Orikasa
"In that case... I'll be Sam."

The awkward atmosphere finally began to lift.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... Tom, what did you do yesterday?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I went shopping with Sam."
Miho Orikasa
"I had a lot of fun."
Nozomi Anesaki

"You get along very well."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you gay?"
Ayumu・Miho・Nozomi
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No！！！ Kidding！！！"

Ayumu-kun freaked out.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"How does that even follow?! This exercise is so weird...!"
Miho・Nozomi
"..."

Talk about bad timing...

In the end, the day passed with that awkward tension hanging over us until the final homeroom ended.

Miho Orikasa
"W-well, see ya."

Miho gave us a stiff goodbye before quickly heading off to club activities.
It didn't feel like the right time to stop her. Not that I had any idea what I'd even say if I did...
This can't go on like this...
I slumped forward, resting my head on my desk.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Nozomi-chan, do you have a student council meeting today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mm, yeah... That's right."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Then I'll wait for you in the library while I get some work done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? You'll wait for me?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. There's something I want to talk to you about."

...I guess it's about Miho.
I knew Ayumu-kun had been worried about what was going on between Miho and me all day.
I couldn't fully process these complicated feelings on my own either, so I also wanted to talk with him about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right then... see you later."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. See you."

After the meeting was over, I headed to the entrance with Ayumu-kun.
There were lots of students heading home from their clubs, and I could spot a few of my classmates here and there.

Female student
"Bye-bye, Nozomi!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Bye-bye."
Male student
"See ya, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See ya."
Male student
"...You too, Kuraguchi."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Uh... yeah... goodbye."

Our classmates were gradually starting to come around to Ayumu-kun, too.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hey..."

As we crossed the courtyard, Ayumu-kun became more serious and broached the subject.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's about Orikasa-san..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"That thing from yesterday... makes you uncomfortable, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I hesitated, unsure how to respond.
"Uncomfortable" didn't quite describe it. To me, it was simply unthinkable.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I know there are people who like that sort of thing, and I've never really had a problem with it, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's Lord Wald we're talking about...! Lord Wald! You know, *the* Lord Wald!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah... yeah... I can see how that'd be a dealbreaker for you, Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because... Lord Wald only loves the heroine (= me)... I'm the only one for him..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"B-but..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You have me... right...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm sorry! I take it back! I know I can't beat Lord Wald...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yes...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I love you."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"...Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But that's different."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I suppose so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"The other characters can be gay or whatever... I don't care. But... but Lord Wald..."

Eek!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I can't accept this...! Lord Wald can't be gay...! No, no way...!"

Just as I said that, I heard footsteps approaching from behind.
Someone ran past us.
And that person was...

Nozomi Anesaki
"M-Miho?!"

Miho didn't even look back when her name slipped out of my mouth. She just kept running.
Oh no... She… heard that, didn't she...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sniff*... Ayumu-kuun..."

Grab.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Wh-whoa... Nozomi-chan, wait...! You can't just hug me here...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"B-but what am I supposed to dooo... *sob*..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"J-just calm down, okay…? Come on, over here...!"

Ayumu-kun led me along, and before I knew it, we'd arrived at the park.
By then, I'd calmed down, but when I replayed what I'd said in my head, I just felt miserable.
I never should have said something like that in front of Miho.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Here, orange juice."

I didn't even notice when Ayumu-kun bought us some canned drinks.
He sat down beside me, and for the next few minutes, we drank in silence. Finally, he spoke.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You and Orikasa-san have known each other since your first year, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, we have..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Did you two become friends right after you started school?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I guess so..."

I think the first time I talked to Miho was during homeroom after the entrance ceremony.

That day, I was more nervous than I'd ever been in my life.
In middle school, I was an otaku through and through, with a pretty lame look to match.
But in high school, I was determined to leave that old version of myself behind and reinvent myself.
Put simply, I wanted to make a fresh start.
My brand-new uniform fit me well, and Shun had carefully styled my hair. At least on the outside, I looked perfect.
Inside, though, I was a nervous wreck.
Ayumu-kun was the only friend I'd ever had. Basically, I had no idea how making friends was supposed to work.
Of course, I'd practiced with Shun beforehand. We'd gone over how to approach strangers and rehearsed it countless times.
But I'd never actually done it in real life, so I knew things wouldn't go so smoothly.
And then the entrance ceremony came to an end without me ever putting my "talk to someone nearby" training to use.

When I arrived at the classroom, several groups had already formed among students who'd come from the same middle schools.
I was the only student from my middle school who'd enrolled here. I didn't know a single person.
Naturally, I ended up spending the time before homeroom all by myself.
I wouldn't learn this until later, but apparently Miho had already been paying attention to me.

And before I'd said a single word to anyone, homeroom began.
Just as I'd expected, it was time for us to introduce ourselves.

What I said and did here would determine my entire high school experience.
I had to make a good impression on my classmates.
I absolutely could not screw this up.
The pressure sent my nerves through the roof.

Teacher
"All right, next... Anesaki-san, please introduce yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Oh no, what do I do... my voice cracked...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(O-okay... Um... My name. Just say my name...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Huh...? Wait... What was my name again...? Oh, r-right... Anesaki. Anesaki...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"M-my name is Anesaka—"
Nozomi Anesaki
(I stumbled over my own name...!)

I thought it was over for me. I don't remember a thing I said after that.
They did clap for me, so I guess I must have managed to give a reasonably normal introduction.
Still, the moment I sat down, I felt miserable.
I was the only one who had messed up like that.
Shame washed over me, and I wanted nothing more than to go home and hide away in my room.
And then…

Teacher
"All right, next. Orikasa-san, please."
Miho Orikasa
"Yes."
Miho Orikasa
"Um... my name is Orisaka—"
Nozomi Anesaki
(She messed up...!)

Yes, Miho fumbled her introduction, too.
Perhaps the fact that two people had stumbled over their words back-to-back prompted soft laughter from around the room.
It wasn't the kind of laugh meant to belittle or make fun of anyone. Rather, it was warm and helped lighten the mood.
I realized that my mistake wasn't such a big deal after all.
After the homeroom ended, someone tapped me on the shoulder from behind.
I quickly turned around, and there was Miho, smiling at me.

Miho Orikasa

"Anesaki-san, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... Uh... y-yeah...!"
Miho Orikasa
"I'm Miho Orikasa. I flubbed it earlier and said 'Orisaka,' but it's actually 'Orikasa.' People mix it up pretty often, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right... I-I see..."

She was a talkative girl. That was my first impression of Miho.
She carried herself with confidence, and she spoke clearly and assertively. It was hard to believe she'd stumbled over her words earlier.

Miho Orikasa
"You're really nervous, aren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh..."
Miho Orikasa
"Actually, I noticed you way before homeroom started."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?! Wh-why?"
Miho Orikasa
"I just thought, 'Wow, that really cute girl looks so pale.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"U-uh..."

I didn't know how to react.
Unable to do anything but stand there frozen, I watched as Miho giggled.

Miho Orikasa
"Ahaha, your face is bright red! So cute! Nozomi, you're adorable."

Before I knew it, she was calling me by my first name.

Miho Orikasa
"Just call me Miho. No honorifics!"

The conversation was moving at such a breakneck pace that I couldn't keep up.
As I stood there dazed, nodding along to Miho's rapid-fire chatter, several of the girls gathered around us.

Female student
"What's up, what's up? What're you talking about, Miho? Sounds fun!"
Female student
"Let me in on it, too!"

I realized they were probably girls who had gone to the same middle school as Miho. It seemed she already had plenty of friends at this school.

Miho Orikasa
"I was just saying how cute Nozomi is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"
Female student
"Nozomi? Oh, Anesaki-san, right? I thought she was cute, too."
Female student
"It was pretty funny watching you stumble over your introduction, though."
Female student
"Then Miho fumbled right after you! I seriously thought you two were doing a comedy bit together."
Miho Orikasa
"Actually, we were! Right, Nozomi?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We were?!"
Female student
"Wait, what? Miho, sure, but Anesaki-san, too? You're that kind of girl?"
Female student
"I wouldn't have guessed."
Female student
"Oh, right! I'm Airi Taniguchi. Just call me Airi. Can I call you Nozomi, too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, s-sure..."
Female student
"I'm Nao. Nice to meet you!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nice to meet you…"

...That's how it went.
Through Miho, I gradually expanded my circle of friends.
The more time I spent with her, the more her confidence rubbed off on me.
It was all thanks to Miho that I was able to find my place at this school.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It seems that... Orikasa-san is a special friend to you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I'm really grateful to Miho."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I see... I guess she is to you what you are to me, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"You're the one who helped me find my place at this school. I'm truly grateful for that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What I want to know is…"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah...?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"After you found out about Orikasa's hobby, did it change how you feel about her?"

How I feel about her...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Does she make you uncomfortable now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not at all!"

I answered immediately. Of course not.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good. Then I think everything will be okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…But… I don't know what I'm supposed to do…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I love Miho no matter what she is into."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But I don't think I can ever like Miho's hobby. I just… can't accept it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But if I want to make up with Miho… I have to, don't I?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Why is that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Does that mean I can't be with you unless I like all of your hobbies?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course not."

I answered right away again, which suddenly brought to mind the conversation Ayumu-kun and I had after school yesterday.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I don't think being close to someone means you have to get involved in every aspect of their life."

I suppose that's what it comes down to.
Whatever Miho may be, first and foremost, she's my friend.

Nozomi Anesaki
"After the weekend… I'll talk things through with Miho."
Ayumu Kuraguchi

"Yeah. I like seeing you two get along, I hope things get back to normal soon."

His gentle smile put me at ease. I was glad I'd talked to Ayumu-kun. I was glad he was there for me.

The next day, Saturday, I got up early and headed for the station.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Good morning, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning. …You look sleepy."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I never get up this early on weekends…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry for dragging you along."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I'm doing this because I want to. ...Anyway, shall we go?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah!"

When we arrived at Animart, people were already lined up, even though the store wouldn't open for another hour.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No way… There's already this many people in line…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Wow… WataPuri really is something…"

I walked toward the end of the line in a daze when I caught sight of someone familiar among the crowd.
Miho.
She noticed me too. Our eyes met, and we both froze.
After an awkward little nod to each other, we quietly looked away.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…Aren't you going to talk to her?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I can't right now… I'm not ready. I'll talk to her later…!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"If you say so…"

Once we reached the end of the line, I could see Miho standing farther ahead. She must have come even earlier than we did.
I guess that's just how much WataPuri means to her.
Maybe we enjoy it in completely different ways… but even so, it makes me happy to know that we both love the same thing.

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"What are you hoping to get, Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… Anything with Lord Wald would be great, but… I really want one of the mini figures."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Only two tries per person, huh… That might be difficult."
Nozomi Anesaki
"There are two different Lord Wald figures. I really want both, but… there's no way I'll get this lucky."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Even with my two tries, that's only four chances… Hopefully we can at least get one."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, you're going to play too?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It'll improve our odds, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun..."

You're becoming more and more like a prince…

And then, after the lottery...

Nozomi Anesaki
"No way… I got it… A Lord Wald figure…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, I got a Lord Wald figure too."

We got both Lord Wald figures so easily, it was almost anticlimactic.
The other two prizes were a Lord Wald plastic folder and a Lord Wald keychain. I was in Lord Walt heaven. I could only conclude the gods were on my side.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"That's great, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…! Thank you, Ayumu-kun...!"

…Even as I savored my happiness, Miho's image lingered somewhere in the back of my mind.
I looked around.
Amid the crowd, I spotted her walking away toward the station alone.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Looks like Orikasa-san's heading home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to talk to her…!"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Okay. I'll kill some time around here, so take as long as you need."

Ayumu-kun's smile gave me the push I needed, and I immediately took off after her.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho...!"
Miho Orikasa
"?!"

Miho spun around at once, her eyes widening in surprise.
I held her gaze and took a deep breath.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho, are you heading home now?"
Miho Orikasa
"Uh… yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could we... talk for a bit?"
Miho Orikasa
"...Sure."

After walking for a while, we sat down on a bench in a nearby park.
Neither of us had said anything, but the silence didn't feel uncomfortable.
I think Miho would agree with me.
"Even if two people don't share exactly the same tastes and interests, that doesn't mean their relationship has to change."
But that only holds true if the other person feels the same way.
I imagine my interests must have been hard for Miho to accept, too.
And yet she stayed by my side and never treated me differently.
Whatever kind of person I was, she still wanted to be my friend.
The fact that she hid her hobby from me was proof of that. She probably didn't want to risk ruining our friendship.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho, what did you win in the lottery?"

I found it surprisingly easy to start talking to her in our usual way.

Miho Orikasa
"A Melchior figure."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you only try once?"
Miho Orikasa
"No, twice. And I got a Melchior figure both times."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait… seriously…?"
Miho Orikasa
"I did want one, so I was glad about that… but I would've liked the other one to be something different…"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Tough luck…"
Miho Orikasa
"What about you, Nozomi?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Two Lord Wald figures, a Lord Wald plastic folder, and a keychain."
Miho Orikasa
"Whoa, that's awesome. You got everything you were after, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I couldn't have done it without Ayumu-kun's help."
Miho Orikasa
"Gucchi came through."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I took one of Lord Wald's figures out of the bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Here, you can have this."
Miho Orikasa
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho… you wanted this one too, right?"

I remembered what Miho had tried to buy the day before yesterday.
Lord Wald's and Melchior's charms.
And then there was *that*... thing with Lord Wald and Melchior.
I guess Miho likes the two of them as a pair.

Miho Orikasa
"Huh... but... i-is it okay...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, you can have it."
Miho Orikasa
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...B-but... I... still... think... that... Lord Wald... is... straight…!"
Miho Orikasa
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"...Hehe."

Miho burst out laughing.

Miho Orikasa
"Yeah, I know. That's just how I prefer it, I can't have fun with it the way you do."

Miho Orikasa
"I like your perspective, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Miho Orikasa
"I'm sorry we don't see things the same way."

Miho gave me a sad smile, and I frantically shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I feel the same! I'm sorry that I don't get it!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"But I still love you, Miho!"

My declaration left Miho speechless, and she stared at me in surprise.

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi!!!"

She suddenly wrapped her arms around me.

Miho Orikasa
"Thank goodness… I thought I was done for…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was freaking out too."
Miho Orikasa
"…You know, I'm into yuri too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"HUH?! Y-yuri?! You mean..."
Miho Orikasa
"I like m/m best, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huuh..."

I suppose I'll never fully understand Miho.

Miho Orikasa
"I love WataPuri too. It's my favorite thing right now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Me too."
Miho Orikasa
"Yeah, I know. That's why I was so happy."

Miho pulled away from me with a look of relief on her face.

Miho Orikasa
"Did you hear there's another WataPuri lottery next month?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"What? Really?"
Miho Orikasa
"Yeah. So… next time, wanna line up together?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah! Let's do it!"

Even if our tastes don't completely align, there are plenty of other things we can share.
I hope we will discover more of what we have in common and enjoy it together.

AYUMU FANBOOK

Epilogue 3: Rainy season

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... shoot."

It wasn't until after I changed my shoes that I realized I'd forgotten something.
The sky had been growing cloudy since the afternoon, but now, as school let out, it seemed the rain had finally begun to fall in earnest.
When I looked outside and sighed, Ayumu-kun, standing beside me, tilted his head curiously.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Did you forget your umbrella?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... I did."

When I left home, the sky had been perfectly clear, so the thought of bringing an umbrella hadn't crossed my mind at all.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"The weather forecast said it was going to rain this afternoon."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really? Then you brought an umbrella, right, Ayumu-kun?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yeah. I can share it with you…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I mean... if you're okay with it, of course..."

Ayumu-kun added timidly, a faint blush coloring his cheeks.
Seeing him like that made my own face feel hot, but I nodded without hesitation.
We might get teased if we run into somebody, but I suppose there's no point worrying about it now.

Rain kept sneaking in under the umbrella, slowly soaking my shoulder.
That clearly bothered Ayumu-kun and he kept adjusting the angle of the umbrella, but the height difference between us made it rather troublesome.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You've grown, Ayumu-kun."

Standing close to him like this, I was reminded of it all over again.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh... you think so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I didn't even notice when we first met again."

In my memory, Ayumu-kun was about my height, maybe a little shorter.
But at some point, he had grown into the tall figure standing before me, looking down at me from above.
Because of his gentle demeanor, he wasn't intimidating in the slightest. But... he seemed more manly now all of a sudden, and I found myself feeling self-conscious around him.
...Honestly, I think Ayumu-kun has gotten way too handsome.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Um, Nozomi-chan..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What is it?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Could you move a little closer?"

Ayumu-kun was still preoccupied with the rain, trying to figure out the best way to hold the umbrella.
My heart fluttering with nervous excitement, I drew closer to him.
...Except somehow, it felt like we'd ended up even farther apart.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Wait... Ayumu-kun?"

Why are you backing away?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah, s-sorry... I just..."

Ayumu-kun awkwardly shuffled back into his original spot, rubbing the back of his neck with a sheepish smile, his face bright red.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"It's just... kind of embarrassing, you know?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? W-well... yeah, I guess so."

It shouldn't have been anything new to us by now.
Ever since we started dating...

No, even back in middle school, we'd been this close to each other plenty of times.
What had I felt back then, being beside him like this?
...I couldn't quite remember anymore.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What were we like back in middle school?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh? Hmm... pretty much the same as we are now... no, I guess that's not exactly true."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you think we've changed?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Obviously."

Ayumu-kun shot me a quick look, then faced forward again.
An awkward silence fell between us.
...Yeah. I guess we have.
I don't remember ever feeling this self-conscious back then.
Ayumu-kun had grown taller.
My appearance had changed significantly.
We'd lived in different worlds and formed different values along the way.
But somehow, being beside Ayumu-kun still felt perfectly natural.
That was the same as it had been back then.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Oh, the sky's clearing up."

At the sound of his voice, I looked up to find a patch of clear sky peeking through the leaden clouds.
The rain had stopped at some point, and the world around us was filled with quiet ambient sounds.
Ayumu-kun stopped and slowly folded up the umbrella.
And so, we started walking again, settling back into our usual distance.

Epilogue 4: Hatsumōde

(Ayumu's POV)
I took a deep breath.
Straightened my back. Pressed the intercom.
While I waited, I always thought about how I should greet her and what kind of expression I should make.
For today, I decided, a simple "Happy New Year" would be enough.
And a natural smile.
I couldn't let either my nerves or excitement show.

I wanted to come across as a calm, confident guy, like Shun or the student council president.
Three minutes passed while I stood there thinking about all this.
When I tilted my head, puzzled by the unusually long wait, I eventually heard a set of hesitant footsteps approaching.
I looked up...

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Ah!"

...in an instant, every word I'd prepared and every expression I'd practiced disappeared from my mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, did I keep you waiting?"

Nozomi-chan opened the gate with an apologetic look on her face.
I wondered what kind of expression I had on my face right now. I hoped I didn't look too creepy.
I desperately tensed the muscles in my face.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"H-happy... N-new... Year..."

When I finally managed to get the words out, Nozomi-chan's expression suddenly stiffened for some reason.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun… are you angry…?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?!"

That's what I looked like?
I quickly relaxed my face and shook my head.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"N-no, no. It's not that. I'm not angry at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really...? I'm so sorry for keeping you waiting. I had a little trouble getting my kimono on."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"No, no, it's fine. Really, I don't mind at all."

I silently lamented my terrible conversational skills.
I knew there were plenty of other things I should have said.
"Your kimono is beautiful." "It really suits you." "You look like a doll."
If this were a scene in a novel, I could come up with the protagonist's dialogue without even thinking.
Unfortunately, I just didn't have the protagonist-level skills to pull any of that off in real life.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…H-hey, what do you think?"

Nozomi-chan, her cheeks flushed red, timidly lifted the sleeve of her kimono.
Cursing myself for being too pathetic to say anything before she even had to ask, I opened my mouth and blurted out the first thing that came to mind.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"C-cute! …Really cute."

…Could someone with such an impoverished vocabulary truly aspire to become a writer?
I was a little worried, but it seemed my feelings had reached Nozomi-chan all the same.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe… I'm glad."

She gave me a dazzling smile, shining more brightly than any heroine in the stories I had written.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's 'two bows, two claps, one bow,' right?"
*Standard ritual for praying at a Japanese Shinto shrine.
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Yep, exactly. Watch your step."

I helped Nozomi-chan to the front of the shrine and stood beside her.
I dropped a coin into the offering box, rang the bell, and performed two bows and two claps.
As I held my hands together, I discreetly stole a glance at Nozomi-chan standing next to me.
…She was serious.
Her tightly shut eyelids were trembling ever so slightly.
She looked cute like this, too—
Then again, thinking things like that in the presence of the gods was hardly appropriate.
I brushed those worldly thoughts aside and turned my attention back to the shrine, bringing my hands together once more.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ayumu-kun, did you make a wish?"

Once we were done praying, Nozomi-chan asked me that as we threaded our way through the crowd.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Did you know a shrine isn't actually a place for making wishes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, seriously? Oh no… I wished for something like my life depended on it…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"What did you wish for?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"…What do you think?"

I pondered.
What could Nozomi-chan possibly be that serious about…?

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Maybe a sequel to WataPuri?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I wished for that, too."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"…So it wasn't just one wish."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Once I put my hands together, all sorts of things started popping into my head…"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Haha. That's so you, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's a little embarrassing."

A small sigh rose into the cold air as a puff of white vapor.
Was she beating herself up over this?
Nozomi-chan possessed the specs of a perfect 2D anime girl, but she also had some clumsy little imperfections of a real person.
She seemed to think of those traits as something to be ashamed of, but to me, they were trivial.
Because at her core, she hadn't changed in the slightest since the day we first met.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I like that honest side of you, Nozomi-chan."

When I said that, Nozomi-chan looked a little taken aback.

Nozomi Anesaki
"A-actually..."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I prayed… that I could always be with you, Ayumu-kun."
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Huh?"

Then she lowered her head bashfully.
I felt as though my heart had been squeezed tight, and I couldn't come up with anything clever to say in response.
I loved how straightforward Nozomi-chan was, but when she went this far, she was absolutely lethal.
I tried to soothe my racing heart and said:

Ayumu Kuraguchi

"I didn't really wish for anything..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I just thanked the gods for everything that's happened."

Our reunion had been brought about by a "coincidence" of astronomical improbability.
It would be no stretch to call it a "miracle."
It was something completely beyond my control.
I could never thank the gods enough for giving me that chance.
And as for the happiness that came afterward, I owed my thanks to the girl who had found the courage to choose to stand by my side.

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"I look forward to spending another year with you."

In the end, I could only come up with something cliché.
But I'm sure my feelings came through to her.
We reached for each other's hands at the same time and walked together through the bustling crowd.